

புதிய வரலாறு...



J.E.E Mains 2026 Results (Session - 1)

**J.E.E (முதன்மை) தேர்வில்
448 அரசுப் பள்ளி / மாதிரி பள்ளி
மாணவர்கள் தேர்ச்சி !!**

J.E.E (Mains) தேர்வில் உயர் மதிப்பெண்கள் பெற்ற அரசுப் பள்ளி மாணவர்கள் !



S.பிரவீன்
99.53 %ile

போளூர், திருவண்ணாமலை



R.நரேஷ்
99.50 %ile

தென்னம்பாளையம், திருவண்ணாமலை



A.வேல்முருகன்
99.42 %ile

நெமிலி, இராணிப்பேட்டை



K K சுகன் குமார்
99.17 %ile



V P ஹீகாந்த்
98.80 %ile



R ஹீஹரி
98.57 %ile



V மனோஜ்
98.45 %ile



M ஜீவா
98.22 %ile



E அரிஸ்தரன்
98.10 %ile



S புவனேஸ்வர
97.95 %ile



B ஹரிஹரன்
97.90 %ile



R கிர்த்திவாசன்
97.79 %ile



S பால முருகன்
97.68 %ile



A அஷ்ரப் அலி
97.68 %ile



G G ஜெகதீஸ்
97.05 %ile



V நிதிஷ் ஆனந்த்
96.06 %ile



A பனிதிரபிரா
96.88 %ile



P தனுஷ்
96.87 %ile



V பிரதீஷ்
96.72 %ile



P நளகுமாரன்
96.63 %ile



G முகிலன்
96.44 %ile



A ஹரிபிரசாத்
96.24 %ile



S துளசிராஜ்
96.09 %ile



G J விக்கேஷ்
96.09 %ile



V காமேஸ்
95.99 %ile



S முகமது இரஃபான்
95.75 %ile



M கௌஷிகாவதனி
95.68 %ile



M மோகன்ராஜ்
95.21 %ile



M விமல்குமார்
95.18 %ile



G பரத்
95.08 %ile



S துரணிதரன்
95.06 %ile



M ஷ்மிளா
95.01 %ile



N கிர்த்தி மாலினி
94.92 %ile

தமிழ்நாட்டின் வளர்ச்சிப் பயணத்தில் ஒருவரையும் பின்தங்க விடமாட்டோம் !!



A Special Publication from The Hindu Group

FAIRS & FESTIVALS

TRADITIONAL CUSTOMS AND ANCIENT CULTURES OF TAMIL NADU

Tamils have traditionally celebrated festivals to mark the changing seasons, and these celebrations were not confined to spring alone. Even the summer months were filled with festivals that reflected the rich cultural heritage and customs of the people. Deeply rooted in ancient customs and traditions, many of these festivals gradually assumed religious overtones.

The coffee-table book Fairs and Festivals of Tamil Nadu, vividly captures the history and spirit of these celebrations through eye-catching photographs and engaging write-ups. While urbanisation has diminished the charm of some festivals, their spirit continues to endure. The book inspires readers to travel across the State and experience these vibrant festivals firsthand.

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TRADE TALKS

Canadian PM to arrive in India on Feb. 27

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Energy shift through green ammonia

India's approach can shape global standards

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



CALYPSO TIME

Hetmyer on song as WI crushes Zimbabwe

SPORT » PAGE 15

NEARBY



Prepared to face ED, I-T Dept. and CBI, says Stalin

CHENNAI If the BJP brings in "its forces" in the form of the ED, the Income Tax Department, and the CBI, "we are very well prepared to face them," Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin said on Monday. » **PAGE 6**

Vijay rejects CM's 'Tamil Nadu vs Delhi' claim

VELLORE TVK founder and actor Vijay on Monday rejected Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's claim that the coming polls would be a "contest between Tamil Nadu and New Delhi". The real fight would be between the TVK and the DMK, he said. » **PAGE 6**

Centre unveils policy to tackle terrorism threats

PRAHAAR states that India faces terrorist threats on all three fronts — water, land and air; the policy adds that capacities have been developed to protect critical sectors of the economy

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Union Home Ministry on Monday released the country's first-ever anti-terror policy, emphasising that other than terror sponsored from across the border, "criminal hackers and nation states continue to target India through cyber-attacks".

The policy — titled PRAHAAR — has been uploaded on the Ministry's website.

It states that India faces terrorist threats on all three fronts — water, land and air — and that capacities have been developed to protect critical sectors of the economy, including power, railways, aviation, ports, defence, space and atomic energy, from both

Protection plan

India has released its first-ever National Counter Terrorism Policy and Strategy, PRAHAAR



■ The nine-page document details the threat-profile, counter-terrorism strategy and the way forward

■ It lists key agencies responsible for specific tasks

■ It stresses that terrorism is not linked to any specific religion, ethnicity, nationality or civilisation

Assessing threats: India has been affected by 'sponsored terrorism,' the policy says.

state and non-state actors.

The Hindu first reported on December 23, 2025, that the National Counter Terrorism Policy and Strategy had been finalised and would be released soon. The policy underlines that "India does not link terrorism to any specific religion, ethnicity, nationality or civilisation". However, it notes that India has been affected by "sponsored terrorism" from across the border, with "Jihadi terror outfits as well as their frontal organisations" continuing to plan, coordinate, facilitate and execute terror

attacks. "India has been on the target of global terrorist groups such as al-Qaeda and IS, which have been trying to incite violence in the country through sleeper cells," it says, adding that extremists operating from foreign countries have hatched conspiracies to promote terrorism.

"Their handlers from across the border frequently use the latest technologies, including the use of drones, for facilitating terror-related activities and attacks in Punjab and J&K. Increasingly, terrorist groups are engaging organised criminal networks for logistics and recruitment to execute and facilitate terror strikes in India," the policy says.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 10**

Four die after consuming 'adulterated milk' in A.P.

T. Appala Naidu
RAJAMAHENDRAVARAM

Four elderly persons have died from acute renal failure after consuming adulterated milk in Rajamahendravaram City in Andhra Pradesh, the East Godavari district administration said on Monday.

Officials said 12 people, including the dead, had taken ill after consuming the milk. Eight victims are suffering from anuria (absence of urine), and are undergoing treatment. Three of them are children aged below four and are critical, said doctors.

East Godavari District Collector Kirthi Chekuri said the victims consumed milk supplied by the same vendor, Addala Ganeswara Rao. The vendor, who procured milk from 46 dairy farmers and supplied to 106 families, has been detained.

"All the 12 persons are from Swaroop Nagar and



Tragic incident: A health official collecting blood sample from a person who consumed milk supplied by the vendor. PTI

Chowdeswari Nagar areas of Rajamahendravaram," Ms. Kirthi said.

"People in the age group of 50-70 and those below five years are prone to anuria. A State-level expert team has collected blood samples from 73 families who consumed milk supplied by the vendor. The samples have been sent to the forensic laboratory for tests," she said. Experts have also collected the fodder given to the cattle for tests, she said.

Superintendent of Police D. Narasimha Kishore said post-mortem reports, which are awaited, will establish the reasons that caused anuria and acute renal failure.

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu announced an *ex gratia* of ₹10 lakh each for the families of the dead.

Former Chief Minister Y. S. Jagan Mohan Reddy alleged that negligence in enforcing food safety norms has endangered public lives and demanded strict action.

Air ambulance with seven aboard crashes in Jharkhand forest

Press Trust of India
RANCHI

A Delhi-bound air ambulance carrying seven persons crashed in a forest near Simaria in Chatra district of Jharkhand on Monday, Ranchi airport Director Vinod Kumar said.

Search and rescue teams have been dispatched, but there was no immediate confirmation about casualties, officials said. The crash occurred after the air ambulance took off from the Ranchi airport at 7.10 p.m.

The ambulance had lost contact with air traffic control around 20 minutes after take off.

Inclement weather could be a reason for the crash, but the actual rea-



Wreckage of the air ambulance after it crashed near Simaria in Chatra district of Jharkhand. PTI

son would be ascertained only after a probe, Mr. Kumar added.

An Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) team is being dispatched for investigation.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 10**

Final poll rolls after SIR show Tamil Nadu has 5.67 crore voters

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu had more than 5.67 crore electors as the Election Commission of India published the final electoral rolls of the State on Monday after the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise.

The list includes 2,89,60,838 women, 2,77,38,925 men, and 7,617 third-gender electors. Since the publication of the draft rolls last December, 27.53 lakh eligible electors have been included and 4.23 lakh ineligible electors deleted. In total, the electorate went up by about 24 lakh since the draft rolls were published.

About 74 lakh entries have been deleted since

Since the draft rolls were published in December last, 27.53 lakh eligible electors have been included

October last when the EC froze the rolls that had 6.41 crore electors. When the draft rolls were published in December last year, there were 5.43 crore voters. During the claims and objections period, 27,85,195 Form 6 applications were submitted and 27,53,796 were accepted. For objections and deletions, 4,38,425 forms were submitted and 4,23,172 of them were accepted.

RELATED REPORT
» **PAGE 6**

25 troops killed as violence erupts in Mexico after Army kills cartel leader

Agence France-Presse
GUADALAJARA

Twenty-five Mexican troops died in clashes with cartel gunmen following a raid that led to the death of the country's most-wanted drug lord, a top security official said on Monday.

Nemesio 'El Mencho' Oseguera, leader of the Jalisco New Generation Cartel, was wounded in a clash with soldiers in the town of Tapalpa, in Jalisco State, and died while being flown to Mexico City, the Army said on Sunday. He had a \$15 million U.S. bounty on his head.

News of his death triggered cartel members



Conflict zone: A bus set on fire by organised crime groups in Zapopan, Mexico, on Sunday. AFP

across the country to block roads, torch vehicles and businesses, and send fearful residents into hiding.

Security Secretary Omar Garcia Harfuch said

that apart from the 25 National Guard members, a prison guard, a member of the state prosecutor's office, and 30 suspected members of Oseguera's cri-

minal organisation were killed in the clashes.

The streets of the State capital Guadalajara were almost empty as stores, pharmacies and gas stations shut down. The violence spread to the neighbouring Michoacan, where the cartel has a presence, and gripped the resort city of Puerto Vallarta.

The Indian Embassy in Mexico on Monday issued an advisory to Indian nationals residing in the country, urging them to exercise caution and remain indoors amid escalating violence.

CONTINUED ON
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VIT
CHENNAI



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Building on the resounding success of its inaugural edition, The Hindu, in partnership with VIT School of Law, VIT Chennai, presents Justice Unplugged 2026, now convening in New Delhi, the nation's constitutional and legal epicentre.

The conclave addresses key questions, including the impact of Gen AI on legal practice, fundamental rights in the digital age, and improving access to justice, offering aspiring lawyers, law students and young legal professionals a rare opportunity to engage directly with distinguished leaders of the legal fraternity and gain valuable insights.

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INBRIEF



Traffic disrupted as lorry gets stuck in road cave-in

A road cave-in occurred on the Menambedu-Karukku Main Road in Ambattur, trapping a goods lorry and disrupting traffic flow on Monday. For the past few months, sinkholes had developed on Ambattur Karukku Main Road due to damage of the underground sewage pipeline. Residents alleged that each time a cave-in occurred, only temporary repairs were carried out. The incident on Monday led to traffic congestion in the area and caused inconvenience to motorists. Residents urged the authorities to find a permanent solution as the road poses a serious safety risk to motorists. Officials who reached the spot have planned to undertake repair work on the road once again.

Text & Context and Health

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (February 24, Tuesday), the following articles are available:

■ On the independence of the Election Commission [newsth.live/electioncommiexp](#)

■ Unusual ancient gene governs sex of ant, bee, wasp newborns [newsth.live/ancientgene](#)

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

City has 28.3 lakh voters in final electoral roll after SIR

Perambur constituency has the highest number of voters at 2,22,792 while Harbour has the lowest at 1,16,896; a total of 11,73,758 voters have been deleted; pre-revision roll had over 40 lakh electors

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The final electoral roll for the 16 Assembly constituencies in Chennai district following the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise has 28,30,936 electors – 14,64,344 women, 13,65,763 men, and 829 third-gender electors.

The final electoral roll was published by District Election Officer and Greater Chennai Corporation Commissioner (GCC) J. Kumaragurubaran on Monday.

29.31% of voters deleted

A total of 11,73,758 voters (29.31%) have been deleted, with the pre-revision roll released in October 2025 listing 40,04,694 electors. There were 25,79,676 voters in the December 19, 2025 draft roll. Later, during the claims period, 2,70,573 new names were added and 19,313 entries were deleted.

The newly added electors include 1,43,053 women, 1,27,418 men, and 102

Final list

Number of voters in Chennai after the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in each constituency

Assembly constituency	Men	Women	Others	Total
Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar	93,576	1,02,201	79	1,95,856
Perambur	1,07,995	1,14,726	71	2,22,792
Kolathur	99,607	1,07,607	37	2,07,251
Villivakkam	76,947	82,785	32	1,59,764
Thiru. Vi. Ka. Nagar (SC)	85,724	93,008	61	1,78,793
Egmore (SC)	65,677	69,149	53	1,34,879
Royapuram	75,870	81,004	57	1,56,931
Harbour	58,221	58,620	55	1,16,896
Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni	79,412	84,396	58	1,63,866
Thousand Lights	73,500	80,343	65	1,53,908
Anna Nagar	87,325	94,029	48	1,81,402
Virugambakkam	95,025	1,01,461	50	1,96,536
Saidapet	96,950	1,03,685	62	2,00,697
Thiyagarayanagar	74,682	80,228	33	1,54,943
Mylapore	93,017	1,01,691	23	1,94,731
Velachery	1,02,235	1,09,411	45	2,11,691
Total	13,65,763	14,64,344	829	28,30,936

third-gender electors. Perambur constituency recorded the highest number of additions with 24,142 new voters, followed by Virugambakkam with 23,113, and Velachery with 23,023. Harbour constituency registered the lowest new enrolments at 7,018.

Highest no. of voters

Overall, Perambur constituency retains the highest

number of voters in the district at 2,22,792, while Harbour constituency has the lowest at 1,16,896.

Velachery has 2,11,691 voters, followed by Kolathur (2,07,251), Saidapet (2,00,697), Virugambakkam (1,96,536), Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar (1,95,856), Mylapore (1,94,731), Anna Nagar (1,81,402), Thiru.Vi.Ka Na-

Thiruvallikeni (1,63,866), Villivakkam (1,59,764), Royapuram (1,56,931), Thiyagarayanagar (1,54,943), Thousand Lights (1,53,908), and Egmore (1,34,879).

More young voters

The number of young electors aged 18 and above increased from 20,904 to 62,005.

Voters aged above 85 years rose from 22,293 to 23,350, and electors with disabilities increased from 9,598 to 12,347.

The number of service electors remained unchanged at 555.

Further, 4,079 polling stations have been established. Velachery has the maximum number of polling stations at 314 while Harbour has the minimum at 192.

The electoral rolls will be available for public viewing at the GCC zonal offices in Tondiarpet, Royapuram, Thiru.Vi.Ka Nagar, Anna Nagar, Teynampet, Kodambakkam, and Adyar, and at all polling station centres, the release said.

Governor felicitates Padma awardees from T.N.; hails contributions of people from various walks of life

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Governor R.N. Ravi on Monday hosted a function at the Lok Bhavan in the city to felicitate the 2026 Padma awardees of Tamil Nadu.

Those who were felicitated included gastroenterologist K.R. Palaniswamy, industrialist and social activist S.K.M. Maellanandhan, medical practitioner and former Tamil Nadu Health Minister H.V. Hande, author and activist Sivasankari, mridangam exponent Thiruvhaar Bakthavathsalam, former Vice-Chancellor of Tamil Nadu Agriculture University K. Ramasamy, exponent of Thirumurai songs tradition *Othuvaar* Thiruthani Swaminathan, Di-



Due recognition: Governor R.N. Ravi with the Padma awardees at the Lok Bhavan in Chennai on Monday. M. SRINATH

rector of IIT Madras V. Kamakoti, veterinary scientist Punnamurthy Natesan, bronze sculptor Rajastapathi Kaliappa Goundar, and Carnatic vocalist duo Gayatri Balasubramanian and Ranjani Balasubramanian.

Suseela, widow of R. Krishnan, who is credited with the revival of Kurumba tribal art through his

cloth paintings, received felicitations on behalf of her husband.

Mr. Ravi said the Padma awards were “a modest way to say thank you for what you have done”. He said, “People from different walks of life, be it art and culture, or industry, or literature, have been building the country for thousands of years.”

When the Republic came into being as an institution to serve the country, it was realised that it would not be enough until the “great sons and daughters” serving the country in their own ways were identified and located, he added.

Dr. Palaniswamy said digestive disorders have become quite common because of our dietary habits and lifestyle. People need awareness to overcome this. Dr. Hande recalled his tenure as the Health Minister of Tamil Nadu when he turned focus on leprosy eradication efforts. “When I took over, in leprosy (incidence), we were second in India. So, I took several steps, including multi-drug regimen. Today, I am glad to tell

you, the leprosy homes are all empty,” Mr. Palaniswamy added.

Prof. Kamakoti spoke about IIT Madras's initiatives to set up over 7,000 rural interaction centres across the country to assist school students find help with studies and establish the Shakti Processor Programme to create an open-source processor ecosystem in India.

Dr. Natesan outlined how his research helped stem losses to Indian dairy farmers, which ran to about ₹20,000 crore annually, due to mastitis and how the “robust Indian knowledge base” led to a reduction in the quantum of drug residue in milk as well as in dung and urine leading to soil fertility conservation.

Van runs over woman while reversing in Tiruvottiyur

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

An 86-year-old woman died after a load van ran over her while reversing inside the premises of the Vadiudai Amman Temple in Tiruvottiyur on Sunday night. The police identified the victim as E. Kaliya Nayagi, a resident of Thiruvottiyur.

She was rushed to a private hospital nearby, where doctors declared her dead at around 1.45 a.m. on Monday.

The Tiruvottiyur police registered a case and arrested the driver, Sarath Sai, 22. The body was later sent to Stanley Medical College Hospital for post-mortem examination.

THE HINDU

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EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN TENDER NOTICE

NOTICE INVITING OPEN TENDER. Tender Notice No. 30/TRD/DNR/OT/25-26 The Divisional Railway Manager, E.C. Railway, Danapur invites sealed open tender on behalf of the President of India for the following works.

Tender No.: TRD/DNR/OT/30/25-26 1. Name of work with its location: POH of 05 nos. 21.6 MVA, 132/25 KV Power Transformer of JAJTSS (2 Nos.), KOOTSS (1 No.), NLD/TSS (1 No.) & DNR/TSS (1 No.) for improving power supply over Danapur Division. 2. Approx cost of the work (NIT value): ₹ 2,27,53,908.62/- 3. Earnest money to be deposited: ₹ 2,63,800.00/- 4. Date & time for online submission and closing of all above tenders: Date & time for online submission of tender: 18.03.2026 up to 12.30 hrs., 5. Website particulars, notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc.: Detailed tender notice, eligibility criteria & tender documents can be seen from the CRIS website: <http://www.ireps.gov.in> & full details of notice can be seen on notice board of Sr. DEE (TRD)/E.C. Railway/ Danapur. All corrigendum will be uploaded on website, if required.

Divisional Railway Manager, E.C.Railway, Danapur PR/1826/DNR/TRD/IT/25-26/40

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice

Tender for Contract for outsourcing of Electrical Maintenance contract including Repair/Rehabilitation/modification/fitment, miscellaneous electrical items in TL Coaches (ICF and LHB) and Repair and reconditioning along with Spares of EBC (2.5 kW) equipments for emergency light in coaches of DHN Division.

For and on behalf of the President of India, E-Tenders on "Two Packet System" are invited from the Firms/Agencies/ Contractors of repute having technical expertise and financial solvency for the following works:-

i) GeM Bid No. & Date : e-tender Notice No. MC-10-OPEN-2025-26 Dated: 19/02/2026, ii) Name of work with its location and completion period. :- Contract for outsourcing of Electrical Maintenance contract including Repair/ Rehabilitation/ modification/ fitment, miscellaneous electrical items in TL Coaches (ICF and LHB) and Repair and reconditioning along with Spares of EBC (2.5 kW) equipments for emergency light in coaches of DHN Division for Three (03) Years. Completion period – 03 years. iii) Approx. Cost of the work : Rs. 4,96,29,456.48 (Rupees Four crore ninety-six lakh twenty-nine thousand four hundred fifty-six and forty-eight paise) only.iv) Earnest Money to be deposited : Rs. 3,98,200.00 (Rupees Three lakh ninety-eight thousand and two hundred) only. v) Date & time for closing of e-tender: 17:00 hrs. on 12/03/2026, Date & time for opening of e-tender : 17:30 hrs. on 12/03/2026, vi) Website particulars <https://www.ireps.gov.in> No manual tender will be accepted against e-tendering.

ADME/C&W/DHN Divisional Railway Manager E. C. Railway, Dhanbad PR/1829/DHN/MECH/IT/25-26/52

Fisherfolk of Chennai and suburbs want subsidised engines to be distributed soon

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Faced with frequent engine breakdowns, fisherfolk of Chennai, Chengalpattu, and Tiruvallur have urged the Fisheries Department to release the subsidy amount for 335 motorised boats meant for 2025.

Each engine costs around ₹75,000, with the State government providing ₹25,000 as subsidy to individual boat-owning fisherfolk.

Community leader 'Kabaddi' Maran said that boat engines last for a maximum of three years after which they need to be repaired frequently.

“If we have proper harbours, the engines will last longer. Here, we park the boats on the sand and the repairs start in just 1.5 years. The mechanics demand quite a lot of money for repairs. We would end up spending ₹25,000 per repair,” he said.

Neelakantan, a fisherman of Nochikuppam said that 22 per-

Each engine costs around ₹75,000, of which ₹25,000 is given by the State government as subsidy to individual boat-owning fisherfolk

sons from his village had applied for engines last year in August and they were yet to get them.

“A month after we applied, someone came and verified our boats and other documents. But nothing happened after that. Earlier, we used to get engines in about a month after we applied for them,” he said.

Community leader K. Bharathi said that Tiruvallur district had applied for 115 engines, Chennai 100, and Chengalpattu 150.

“At this rate, fisherfolk would not get any engines for 2025. We are already in February 2026. Fisherfolk say they plan to stage protests if they don't get the subsidy soon,” he said.

Private hospital removes 20 cm ovarian cyst from 21-year-old

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Doctors of a private hospital in the city performed a fertility-sparing surgery on a 21-year-old IT professional to remove a 20-cm ovarian cyst. It had caused severe abdominal pain due to torsion, a condition in which the ovary twists and compromises its blood supply.

The surgical team from V.S. Hospitals performed an emergency staging laparotomy, an open abdominal procedure to remove the tumour and assess whether the disease had spread.

The cyst was excised along with the affected fallopian tube, while the healthy ovary and other reproductive structures were preserved to safeguard her future fertility.

Girija Ashok Kumar, Senior Consultant Obstetrics and Gynaecology, emphasised that women should not ignore persistent lower abdominal pain, bloating, irregular menstrual cycles, nausea, or sudden severe pain, as these could indicate an underlying ovarian problem, according to a press release.

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BENGALURU EAST CITY CORPORATION

Office of the Executive Engineer (M.P & C.S), Old Madras Road, K.R. Puram, Bengaluru - 560036.

No: BECC/PR/EE(MPCS)/10/2025-26 Date: 23-02-2026

CORRIGENDUM

Subject: Postponing of Tender.

Reference: This Office Short Term Tender Notification No: BECC/PR/EE/MPSC/10/2025-26, Dated: 19-02-2026.

This is for the kind information for Contractors / Bidders / Public that the Short Term Tender Notification published read at ref. is hereby Postponed Due to Technical Reasons. Hence New Calendar of Events is as follows.

Sl. No.	Earlier Calendar of Events	New Calendar of Events to be read
1	Downloading of Tender Documents: 23-02-2026	Downloading of Tender Documents: 26-02-2026
2	Pre Bid Meeting Date: 26-02-2026, 3.00 PM at Executive Engineer Office, K.R. Puram.	Pre Bid Meeting Date: 02-03-2026, 3.00 PM at Executive Engineer Office, K.R. Puram.
3	Last Date for Submitting of Tender Document: 02-03-2026 upto 4.00 PM	Last Date for Submitting of Tender Document: 06-03-2026 upto 4.00 PM
4	Technical Bid to be Opened on 03-03-2026 at 4.30 PM	Technical Bid to be Opened on 07-03-2026 at 4.30 PM

Other than this, everything is remained unaltered.

Sd/- Executive Engineer (MP & CS), BECC.

CHENNAI METROPOLITAN DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Office of the Superintending Engineer, Circle-II, Construction Wing, Fifth Floor, A-Block, E-Road, Koyambedu, Chennai - 600 107

TENDER CUM AUCTION

Tender Cum Auction Dated: 20.02.2026

Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority has invited sealed application for Allotment of 66 shops on monthly rent / lease basis in the newly constructed "Kolathur Modern Market" in Paper Mills Road at Chennai. Applications for the same are being distributed at Koyambedu office of Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority.

Application distribution of date and Time	From 24.02.2026 to 02.03.2026 (except Sunday) From 11.00 AM to 4.00 PM
Application Fee per shop	Rs.1,000/- (Demand Draft in favour of "The Executive Engineer, Division II, CW, Chennai 107")
Application distribute place	Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority, 5th floor, E-Road, Koyambedu, Chennai 107.

DIPR /1334 / TENDER/ 2026

SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER-II Circle-II, CW, CMDA, Ch-107

Civil Aviation Department

Airport Road, Patna – 800014.

TEL. No:- 0612-2225659, 2224423, Fax 0612 2224614

e-mail-cadbihaar@bihar.gov.in

Letter. No: सिविलरिगि (सोजनका) 09-03 / 2026 - 273 Patna

Corrigendum for RFP (PR.No.23415 (Cabinet) 2025-26)

This Corrigendum is issued in continuation of Request For Proposal (RFP) documents published vide Letter No-168 Dt. 05.02.2026 for the Selection of Consultant for Preparation of Detailed Project Reports (DPRs) for Development of Sonpur (Saran) and Sultanganj (Bhagalpur) Greenfield Airports in Bihar, India. Revised Date of Events as Follows :-

Sr No.	Event Description	Date as per Published RFP	Revised Date
1	Last date for submission of Bid	27 th Feb. 2026, by 15.00 Hrs	12 March. 2026, by 15.00 Hrs
2	Technical Bid Opening	10 th March, 2026, by 15.00 Hrs.	13 th March, 2026, by 15.00 Hrs.
3	Technical Presentation	17 th Mar 2026, 12.00 Hrs. onwards (Tentative date) at Conference Hall, Civil Aviation Department, Airport Road, Patna- 800014.	17 th Mar 2026, 12.00 Hrs. onwards (Tentative date) at Conference Hall, Civil Aviation Department, Airport Road, Patna- 800014.

Note : The pre-bid queries received from prospective bidders and the consequent rectifications/amendments in the RFP have been duly examined and published on the Department's official website. For detail corrigendum, kindly visit the department website; www.state.bihar.gov.in/cad

Additional Secretary Civil Aviation Department

PR- 024917 (Cabinet) 2025-26

For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdibihar

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार

Weeks after eviction, pavement dwellers in city wait for housing

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

R. Eswari, 23, who represented India in the Street Child Football World Cup-2018 held in Russia, is now unsure of where she will live. And she isn't alone. Weeks after encroachments were cleared around Broadway, families of Walltax Road continue to wait for housing allotments. The families hope that they are allotted a house nearby, such as the Tamil Nadu Urban Housing Development Board's (TNUHDB) Stanley Hospital-Seven Wells units, which were inaugurated recently, or the tenements on Anna Pillai Street.

"Our belongings were removed by the police and officials from the Greater Chennai Corporation stating that we were encroaching the place. Though they said houses would be given, there has been no update. Only 11 families on this street have received allotments. We were told that we wouldn't get houses as we don't have huts to establish our residence," said Lakshmi, 35, a resident of Rattan Bazaar Road.

Selvi, 65, explained how difficult it was to survive on the streets. "We face a constant threat to our lives, from the traffic to wandering men. We are on alert all the time. There is no toilet or drinking water facility," said Ms. Selvi, who has

been living on the street for three generations now. "Advance for a house is at least ₹50,000. If we could manage that, then why will we continue to live on the streets?" she asked. She said they were evicted a month ago, but only 11 families were allotted houses in the new tenements. "We were told that in the next [TNUHDB] scheme, we would be accommodated. But how do we believe there will be another scheme?" Ms. Eswari, who lived near Memorial Hall, asked.

"Only we know the pain of having to get new copies of birth certificates. We can't get good jobs as we don't always get access to water to bathe. Our health takes a back seat all the time," said the fourth-generation pavement dweller.

Ms. Lakshmi, echoing her sentiments, said her 11-year-old daughter died three years ago after constant exposure to rain and developing epilepsy-like symptoms.

A GCC official said that they only clear encroachments and don't conduct enumerations or allocations. Meanwhile, a TNUHDB official said that the department which clears encroachments takes care of enumeration and they only look at eligibility. P. Sriramalu, Royapuram Ward Committee Chairman, said that he would inspect the area on Tuesday.

Krishna water to bolster city's summer water supply

The water discharge is part of an inter-State agreement; though Chennai's reservoirs are nearly full this month, the Krishna supply will help balance storage and regulate withdrawal, says WRD

WATER WATCH

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Krishna water was released from Andhra Pradesh on Monday to aid Chennai in meeting its summer drinking water demand. The city is likely to receive water at the entry point in Tiruvallur district by Thursday morning.

Though city reservoirs are nearly full this month, the Krishna supply will help balance storage and regulate daily withdrawal, noted the Water Resources Department (WRD). The discharge from the Kandaluru reservoir in Andhra Pradesh followed a representation from the WRD seeking release for the current spell.

"We have asked for release of 500 cubic feet per second of water (cusecs) to enable storage of a minimum of 1,000 million cubic feet (mcft) by mid-March. Water is likely to reach the city faster as the canal bed is wet," said a WRD official.

The water discharge is part of the inter-State agreement under Krishna Water Supply Project, which stipulates water release in two spells: July-October and January-April. Chennai has to be provided



Although the Poondi reservoir, which is the prime storage point of Krishna water, is nearly 98.61% full, inflow would be diverted to other major waterbodies for distribution. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Officials noted that Chennai is well placed to meet its drinking water needs this year

ed with 4,000 mcft of Krishna water between January and April. However, the WRD had earlier deferred the request as the reservoirs in Tiruvallur district were full post-monsoon and lacked storage space.

While there is a demand for irrigation and drinking water en route, the Andhra Pradesh authorities have promised to release additional quantum of water to offset the withdrawal by lo-

calities along the canal, said WRD officials. The department is expecting to receive Krishna water for nearly two months before Andhra Pradesh begins annual maintenance work of the Kandaluru Poondi canal in its jurisdiction.

Currently, the five major reservoirs feeding drinking water to Chennai, including Chembarambakkam and Red Hills, have a combined storage of 9,836 mcft, which is nearly 83.6% of their capacity. Though Poondi reservoir, which is the prime storage point of Krishna water is nearly 98.61% full, inflow would be diverted to other major water bodies from

where it would be drawn for distribution.

On average, about 400 cusecs are being drawn daily from Red Hills and Chembarambakkam for city supply.

Officials noted that Chennai is well placed to meet its drinking water needs this year, given the sufficient storage in the reservoirs. Krishna water and Veeranam supply is expected to augment steady supply during peak summer.

Chennai Metrowater now supplies nearly 1,212 million litres of water daily (mld) and of this, nearly 1,166 mld is supplied to domestic consumers.



Chief Minister M.K. Stalin distributing house patts to residents in Kolathur Assembly constituency on Monday R. RAGU

Kolathur is a model constituency under DMK govt., says CM

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Monday said that his Kolathur Assembly constituency in Chennai has become a model constituency under the "Dravidian Model government".

Listing the various welfare and development measures he had undertaken in the constituency over the past five years, Mr. Stalin claimed that many people from north India visited the hospital located in Periyar Nagar and were impressed by its state-of-the-art facilities.

During his visit, Mr. Stalin inaugurated new buildings for the Arulmigu Kabaleeswarar College of Arts and Science under the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (HR&CE) Department, constructed at a cost of ₹31.45 crore. He said he was proud of having established such a college and commended HR&CE Minister P.K. Se-

karbabu. From the entrance to the classrooms, world-class facilities have been created, he added. Mr. Stalin also inaugurated the *Mudhalvar Padaippagam* established on the college campus.

He further inaugurated various infrastructure projects undertaken by the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority (CMDA) and the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC), including a ration shop and an integrated child development services (ICDS) centre. He also distributed free house patts to around 2,000 beneficiaries.

Ministers K.K.S.S.R. Ramachandran, S. Muthusamy, R. Sakkarapani, P.K. Sekarbabu, Govi. Chezhaan, and Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi; Chennai Mayor R. Priya; MPs Kalanidhi Veeraswamy and R. Girirajan; legislators Thayagam Kavi, A. Vetriazhagan, and Joseph Samuel, and officials, were present.

Two persons arrested for flying kites using manja

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tiruvottiyur police arrested two persons for flying kites using the Chinese *manja*, which was banned for causing deep cuts that in many cases result in fatalities.

Greater Chennai City Police Commissioner A. Arun had issued standing orders banning the manufacture and sale of *manja* thread, as well as the flying of kites using the thread, within the limits of Chennai city.

The accused – Venkatesan, 25, and Arun, 30, of Tiruvottiyur – were arrested. The police seized 10 kites and four spools containing *manja* from them.

Doctors disappointed over Budget, urge DMK govt. to fulfil demands

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Legal Coordination Committee (LCC) for Government Doctors has expressed disappointment and shock over the absence of any announcement to fulfil the promises made to government doctors in the final Budget of the DMK regime.

In a statement, the LCC stated that they expected the government would announce the fulfilment of promises to doctors in the final Assembly session. They also hoped that a government job would be provided for the wife of Vivekanandan, a government doctor who died during COVID-19 duty, and

expected an announcement to double the posts of doctors and nurses in government hospitals.

Unlike Central government doctors and doctors of other States, government doctors in Tamil Nadu are denied equal pay.

The LCC said they were not asking for new pay hikes but to only implement Government Order (G.O.) 354. Despite years of struggle demanding the allocation of ₹25 crore per month for government doctors, the government has not fulfilled the demand.

The LCC requested the Chief Minister to announce doubling of posts for doctors and nurses in government hospitals.

Odisha youth among 2 held for smuggling ganja in city

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Ambattur Prohibition Enforcement Wing arrested two men who smuggled ganja from Odisha near Korattur railway station.

The police found that they were in possession of 31.5 kg of ganja. The ganja was seized and the accused were arrested and taken to the police station for further investigation. The accused were identified as Prakash Majhi, 19, of Odisha and Manikandan, 20, of Tirunelveli district.

Investigation revealed that they had procured the 31.5 kg of ganja from an unidentified person in Odisha with the intention of selling it.

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PERSONAL CHANGE OF NAME I, PERUMAL S, Father of minor child Lakshit P aged 5 years (DOB:10/Aug/2020), hereby declare that my son's name has been changed from Lakshit P to Lakshitdev Perumal. Henceforth, he shall be known as Lakshitdev Perumal for all purposes. By Father/Guardian, Perumal S s/o Sundaresan, No.55/5, Thirukazhukundram Salai, Melavalam, Karunguzhi, Chengalpattu District - 603303	PERSONAL OLD AGE HOME PALLIATIVE CARE at your home Trained Nurses, 24/7, Dr., Physio visits, Lab tests 1800-313-1883 tikotra.com/seniors
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SANKARA NETHRALAYA

3rd Dr. S. S. Badrinath Endowment Oration

by
Dr. Soumya Swaminathan
Chairperson, M. S. Swaminathan Research Foundation
Topic: Well-being as a Way of Life

Tuesday 24 February 2026 | 4:00 PM

Venue: V. D. Swami Auditorium
7th Floor, T. S. Santhanam Floor, KNBIRVO Block
Sankara Nethralaya, Padma Bhushan Dr. S. S. Badrinath Campus
41/18, College Road, Chennai – 600 006

ALL ARE WELCOME

Timings
CHENNAI

TUESDAY, FEB. 24
RISE 06:28 SET 18:17
RISE 11:23 SET 00:00

WEDNESDAY, FEB. 25
RISE 06:27 SET 18:17
RISE 12:21 SET 00:47

THURSDAY, FEB. 26
RISE 06:27 SET 18:17
RISE 13:24 SET 01:51

Chennai Weather

	max	min
Tiruvallur	32	21
Chennai Airport	33	25
Chennai City	32	26

Chennai Airport Today
33°C The morning will be pleasant. The day will be warm. The night also will be pleasant. Dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
34°C The weather will be dry. The day will be warm. The night will be pleasant.

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CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

PSN Disciples' Foundation
TODAY 5.00 pm: at Ragasudha Hall, Mylapore - Annual Day Celebrations - 5.00 pm: Laya Vinyasa on Mridangam by B SUBRAMANI. 6.15 pm: Felicitating MADIRIMANGALAM S. SWAMINATHAN. Chief Guest: K. HARISHANKAR. PSN Foundation Fellowship Award (2026) to R. SRIKRITII, an outstanding and young violinist. 6.45 pm: Vocal Recital by BHARATHI RAMASUBBAN accompanied by Madan Mohan on Violin, B. Sivaraman on Mridangam and Anirudh Athreya on Khanjira. All are welcome.

Rasika Ranjani Sabha Foundation, Ch-4
Today at 6.30 pm Jayakeerthana Creation presents SPARISAM Story Dialogue - Ramanan, directed by Anand Srinivasan Produced by Kalaiyanar Kitcha. Ph. No: 86103 57987. Rasikas Welcome.

Narada Gana Sabha Trust Ph: 24993201
Daily up to 28.2.2026 - Main Hall (Sathguru Gnanananda Hall) 6.30 pm - "Bhagavad Gita"- Chapter 2 - Discourse by Pujyasri Sri Ramana Charna Tirtha (Nochur Swamigal). All are welcome.

SRI PARTHASARATHY SWAMI SABHA
(Estd.:1900) Ph: 9444701446

DANCE FESTIVAL
at R.K. Swamy Auditorium, (Sir Sivaswamy Kalafaya S.S. School) Sundareswarar St., Mylapore
Today - Feb 24 - 5.30 p.m., Bharatanatyam by **PADMAPRIYA R** (Disciple of Guru Vanishree Ravishankar)
7.00 p.m., Bharatanatyam by **HARSHINI R** (Disciple of Guru H. N. Nandhini Suresh, Sri SaiNithyalaya) - **All Are Welcome.**

Presented by : **Nalli**

MISCELLANEOUS

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Son of DMK member held after car mows down official

The Hindu Bureau
HOSUR

The son of a DMK functionary was arrested for mowing down an assistant labour inspector with his SUV on Sunday night.

The accused, Adhithya, 20, son of Seenivasan, a former DMK councillor of Vasanth Nagar, was driving his car in Annai Aravindan Nagar, accompanied by two friends, when he knocked down a two-wheeler outside a house.

Three hospitalised

The owner of the vehicle, Sivamurthy, 54, his son Kirubakaran, 34, and his daughter-in law Hamsavalli, 30, came out of the house and got into an altercation with the accused.

Sivamurthy's granddaughter Nilani was also with them.

Adhithya then rammed his car into them, and Sivamurthy got dragged under the vehicle. He was declared dead at the hospital, while the other three are under treatment.

Southern Railway withholds employees' allowances citing financial constraints

Staff representatives say the decision will adversely affect the workforce and call for urgent remedial action; officials point to insufficient funds and express hope that Railway Board will release a special grant, enabling payment of allowances for February and March along with April salary

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

Citing financial constraints, Southern Railway has decided to withhold payment of certain allowances to employees for the month of February 2026.

Officials expressed hope the Railway Board would release a special financial grant soon, enabling disbursement of allowances for February and March along with the April salary.

According to Railway sources, a note circulated by the Southern Railway headquarters stated that the actual expenditure incurred so far had exceeded the budget allocation for the financial year 2025-26. As a result, several allowances have been excluded from the February salary.

Railway sources said there would be no change

in the payment of basic pay and Dearness Allowance (DA). However, more than a dozen categories of allowances, including medical reimbursement, night duty allowance and ration money, were being withheld, based on circulars issued by Finance Managers.

With funds remaining tight this fiscal, allowances for March may also face delay, the sources said. The note did not specify whether the arrears would be cleared along with the April 2026 salary.

Note of concern

Employee representatives voiced concern over the development. "Even payments for work already done, such as overtime and night duty, are being withheld. These allowances are factored into employees' monthly financial planning," a trade union functionary said.



A note circulated by Southern Railway says the expenditure it incurred so far has surpassed the budget allocation for 2025-26.

Responding to queries, a senior Railway official said while the budget allocation for the fiscal was commensurate with projected demand and estimated expenditure, additional maintenance costs had to be incurred to protect railway assets.

"Operational expenses include onboard house-

keeping services, laundry, coach cleaning and maintenance works. It is a fact that funds are currently insufficient. Some contractor payments have also been kept pending," the official said.

He explained that passenger and freight earnings were directly credited to the Railway Board's ac-

count, which then allocated funds to various zones annually based on requirements. "There is no provision or discretionary power for the General Manager to divert earnings towards payment of salaries or allowances," the official said.

'Unfair labour practice'

The All India Loco Running Staff Association (AILRSA) has sought immediate redressal of the issue as non-payment of allowances would adversely affect the workforce.

"Delaying or denying allowances for work performed is unfair. The operations, maintenance, security and medical departments function round the clock. Withholding due payments amounts to unfair labour practice," said V. Balachandran, central organising secretary of AILRSA. He said paying travel or mileage allo-

wances for two or three months in lump-sum could pose additional financial burden for Loco Pilots and Train Managers, as Income Tax exemptions for such allowances are capped at ₹10,000 a month.

"It is not merely a question of money, but the approach in handling financial administration in a labour-intensive organisation like the Indian Railways. The decision will affect thousands of employees," Mr. Balachandran said.

Incidentally, Southern Railway is among the largest passenger-earning zones in the country.

A senior official said a decision taken late on Monday reduced the number of allowances that were withheld to three — kilometre, travel and overtime. Other allowances may be paid, the official said.

TRB begins scrutinising objections to answer key

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Teachers' Recruitment Board (TRB) has begun the scrutiny of objections to the answer key for the examination held in December 2025 for recruitment to the post of assistant professors in government arts and science colleges and government colleges of education.

The tentative key was released on January 5, 2026, along with an objection tracker. Candidates were instructed to submit their objections and representations online till January 13, 2026.

An expert committee has been set up to go through the objections and come out with the final key before the results are announced.

A total of 47,048 candidates had enrolled for the examination, with 42,064 candidates writing it at 196 centres set up across the State. According to the notification, there were 2,708 vacancies to be filled.

Hospitals cannot treat doctors like workmen in a factory, says Madras High Court

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

In a significant verdict, the Madras High Court has held that private hospitals cannot treat doctors like workmen in a factory and include non-compete and non-solicit clauses in the agreements reached with them.

It has also said rivalry between hospitals is a misnomer since they are expected to be service-oriented and not business-oriented institutions.

Justice N. Anand Venkatesh passed the judgment while dismissing a petition filed by MIOT Hospitals Private Limited for appointing an arbitrator to resolve a dispute between it and cardiothoracic surgeon Balaraman Palaniappan.

The judge also imposed costs of ₹1 lakh on the petitioner hospital and directed the hospital to pay the money to the surgeon.

The judge found that the petitioner-hospital and the surgeon had entered into a

professional agreement on September 8, 2022, for three years. Clause 8.3 of the agreement stated that the surgeon shall not join any rival hospital or set up practice, in the vicinity of 15 km from the petitioner-hospital, for a further period of three years after termination of the contract.

Since the surgeon had terminated the contract midway in 2025 and joined Apollo Hospitals, the petitioner-hospital demanded liquidated damages of ₹42 lakh, which was the sum



The court said hospitals are expected to be service-oriented and not business-oriented.

equivalent to his three months' professional fees, along with interest, and approached the court for ap-

pointment of an arbitrator under the Arbitration and Conciliation Act, 1996.

Shocked by the hospital's act, Justice Venkatesh wrote: "It must be kept in mind that the respondent, who is a doctor by profession, cannot be construed as an employee of the petitioner hospital since, by the very nature of service provided by a doctor, at best, a hospital can only utilise the services and cannot treat a qualified doctor like a regular employee of an organisation."

On clause 8 of the agreement, he said: "It is quite unfortunate that a hospital has incorporated such a clause in an agreement entered into with a doctor.

Either the above clause is as a result of cut, copy and paste syndrome from an agreement, which is regularly entered into between technology companies with their employees, or the petitioner-hospital has forgotten the fact that they are running a hospital to serve the patients and that they are indirectly admit-

ting that the organisation is nothing short of a profit making entity."

The judge also wrote: "Doctors can thrive without hospitals whereas a hospital can never exist without doctors supporting such hospitals by rendering their services. Therefore, by no stretch, a hospital can treat a doctor like a workman in a factory or a technical person or a regular employee employed by an organisation in the field of technology and other service sectors."

The judge held that a professional agreement entered into by a doctor with a hospital would certainly be opposed to public policy if it contained a non-solicitation and/or non-compete clause, and such an agreement would be squarely hit by Section 23 of the Indian Contract Act, 1872. "Consequently, it must be held to be unlawful, unenforceable and void ab initio to that extent," he said.

(For the full report, visit newsth.live/docs)

Steering Committee set up for coordination and governance of health workforce

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government recently constituted a State-level Steering Committee to spearhead the development of a comprehensive Human Resources for Health (HRH) strategy aimed at strengthening the State's public healthcare workforce. The move comes under the World Bank-supported Enhanced Health Service Delivery Program (EHSDDP).

The committee, chaired by the Additional Chief Secretary to Government, Health and Family Welfare, and having the Mission Director of NHM, Tamil Nadu, as its Member-Secretary/Convener, has been constituted to ensure systematic planning, coordination and governance of the health workforce. It has 16 members. The government also gave the nod to the Mission Director of NHM, Tamil Nadu, to develop the HRH Strategies for Tamil Nadu.

Program-for-Results

The EHSDDP uses the World Bank's Program-for-Results model under which funds are released when specific key results are achieved — Disbursement-Linked Indicators. The development and adoption of State-Specific HRH Strategies for public health facilities is one of the DLIs. A mandatory requirement, it will help identify gaps in recruitment, capacity-building, workforce distri-

This strategy will help to improve availability, skills, and retention of health workers at public health facilities

bution and retention.

The implementation of the HRH Strategy will ensure that the States can systematically address workforce gaps and improve availability, skills, and retention of health workers across public health facilities. It will be developed and implemented through a three-tiered, graded approach to ensure comprehensive planning, expert guidance, and effective execution — Technical Working Groups for micro-level planning, data analysis and drafting; Technical Advisory Group for meso-level review, expert inputs and policy refinement; and State-level Steering Committee for macro-level decision-making, approval and overall governance, according to an order by the Health Department.

The Technical Advisory Group and the Technical Working Groups have already been constituted under the NHM and tasked with preparing the technical guidance report and strategy document by coordinating with technical experts and the World Bank, submission of draft strategy recommendations for review and further approval by the Steering Committee.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE



N.R. KRISHNAN, IAS (Retd.,) (87 Years)

Former Secretary, Environment & Forests, Government of India

attained Acharyan Thiruvadigal around 12 noon on 23rd February 2026 at his residence at Second Floor, 46/18, Balaji Nagar 2nd Street, Royapettah, Chennai 600014.

Ceremony starts at 9.00 a.m. on 24.02.2026. Funeral at 11 a.m. at Besant Nagar Crematorium.

Mourning by Anusuya (Wife), Malavika & Srinivas and Ajay & Chitra.

Contact: 9500069767, 9892322183, 9740745239



Shri V. GOVINDARAJAN (Retd. State Bank of India) 22.9.1945 - 22.2.2026

Deeply mourned by Family & Friends.

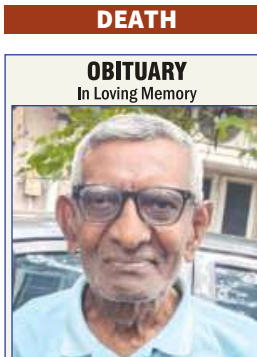
Last respects: 6 to 10.30 am

Final journey: 24 Feb 2026, 11 am

Sakthi Towers, 107, Gandhi Road, Velachery, Chennai, Ph: 9566129555



Dr. SAROJASUNDARARAJAN



Shri V. GOVINDARAJAN (Retd. State Bank of India) 22.9.1945 - 22.2.2026

Deeply mourned by Family & Friends.

Last respects: 6 to 10.30 am

Final journey: 24 Feb 2026, 11 am

Sakthi Towers, 107, Gandhi Road, Velachery, Chennai, Ph: 9566129555



Dr. SAROJASUNDARARAJAN

Passed away on 21-02-2026

Former Principal, Bharathidasan Women's College And

Former Director, Kanchi Maamunivar P.G. Centre

Grieved By Sister Sharada



Dr. G. THIRUMAVALAVAN

BSc., MA, PhD

Retd. Reader in History

DOB: 15.06.1940 DOD: 19.02.2026

Historian, author, gifted teacher, inspiring & supportive son, husband, father, uncle, grandfather, brother and friend.

Remembered by grieving family

Ph: 9840492908



N.R. KRISHNAN, IAS (Retd.,) (87 Years)

Former Secretary, Environment & Forests, Government of India

attained Acharyan Thiruvadigal around 12 noon on 23rd February 2026

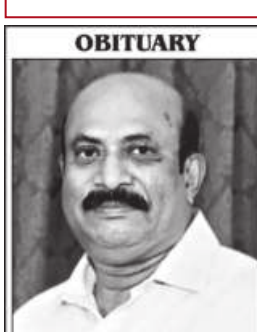
at his residence at Second Floor, 46/18, Balaji Nagar 2nd Street, Royapettah, Chennai 600014.

Ceremony starts at 9.00 a.m. on 24.02.2026. Funeral at 11 a.m. at Besant Nagar Crematorium.

Mourning by Anusuya (Wife), Malavika & Srinivas and Ajay & Chitra.

Contact: 9500069767, 9892322183,

With fond memories from TNRDC & ITEL



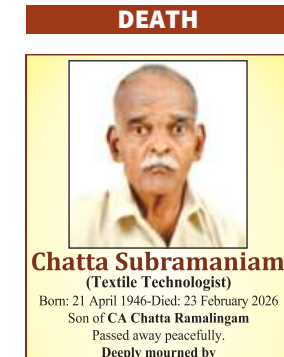
JOSEPH PUTHEN PURAYIL OOMMEN

Manager (Retd.), Abbott

Husband of Late Usha Joseph

DOB: 22.02.2026

Funeral services will be held on Wednesday (25-02-2026) at 10am at the family residence - N295, 26th St., N Block, Annanagar East, Chennai-102, & at 11 am at Jerusalem Mar Thoma Church, Annanagar East. The burial will take place thereafter at Kilpauk Cemetery.



Chatta Subramaniam (Textile Technologist)

Born: 21 April 1946-Died: 23 February 2026

Son of CA Chatta Ramalingam

Passed away peacefully.

Deeply mourned by his Wife, Brothers, Sons, Daughter, Daughter-in-law and Grandsons.

A loving husband and devoted father who cherished his wife and children above all else.



K. Sujatha B.A. BL (73 Yrs.)

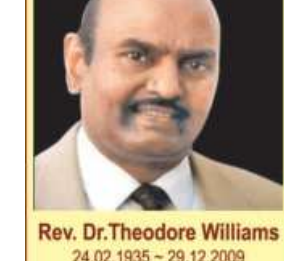
Attained Acharyan Thiruvadi on 23/2/2026

You kept laughing and kept everyone around you laughing! Your laughter keeps ringing in all our ears, all the time.

Forever in your remembrance

Your very dear brother Kuppu, Ramah, Sharanyah, Shreyah and your countless dear friends

Phone : 9840464654



Rev. Dr. Theodore Williams

24.02.1935 - 29.12.2009

Here is my servant, whom I have chosen, the one I love, in whom I delight.

- Matthew 12:18

Remembering gratefully God's chosen servant, who immensely enriched us in CHRIST

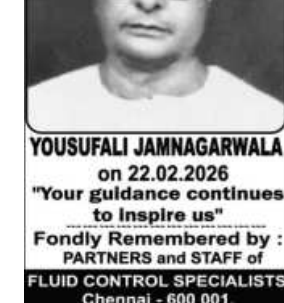
Inserted by: Dr.S.Prince Arockia Doss



Sri T R Narayanan (Raja)

Fondly Remembered by Family, S.Gomathy, Family, Pen. S.Rajy, P.Damotharan, Retd. ICI, P.Pandian, Advertiser, Latha Sundaram, P.Venkatesan, Ex. IBM, Grandchildren & Great Grandchildren

Mod. 793305555



YOUSUFALI JAMNAGARWALA

on 22.02.2026

"Your guidance continues to inspire us"

Fondly Remembered by: PARTNERS and STAFF of FLUID CONTROL SPECIALISTS Chennai - 600 001.



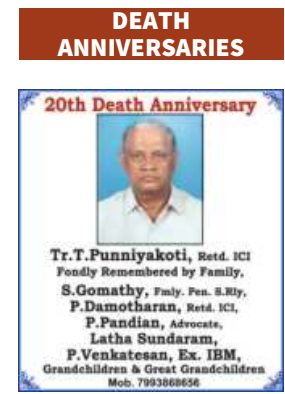
Dr. DEBASHISH DANDA

Founder

Dept. of Clinical Immunology and Rheumatology CMC Vellore.

Remembered every day since 24.02.2024

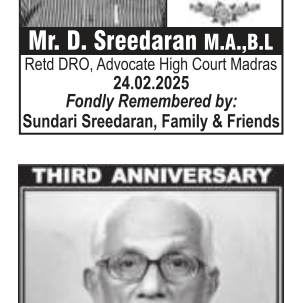
Family, Friends, Students & Patients



Tr. T. Punniyakoti, Retd. ICI

Fondly Remembered by Family, S.Gomathy, Family, Pen. S.Rajy, P.Damotharan, Retd. ICI, P.Pandian, Advertiser, Latha Sundaram, P.Venkatesan, Ex. IBM, Grandchildren & Great Grandchildren

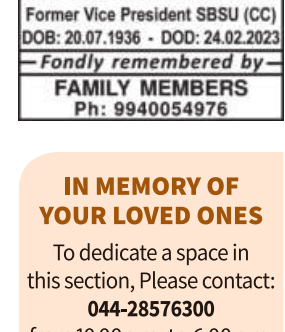
Mod. 793305555



Mr. D. Sreedaran M.A.B.I.

Retd DRD, Advocate High Court Madras 24.02.2025

Fondly Remembered by: Sundari Sreedaran, Family & Friends



Mr. P.N. KRISHNAMURTHY

Retired State Bank of India

Former Vice President SBSU (CC)

DOB: 20.07.1936 - DOD: 24.02.2023

Fondly remembered by: FAMILY MEMBERS

Ph: 9940054976

DONATE EYES GIFT SIGHT



TAMIL NADU WAQF BOARD

No.1, Jaffar Sarang Street, Vallal Seethakathi Nagar,
Chennai - 600 001, Tamil Nadu.

E-TENDER NOTICE

Date:24.02.2026

The Tamil Nadu Waqf Board Invites Requests for Proposal (RFP) from eligible tenderers for repair and improvement works of the toilet sewer system under the Single-Cover system.

➤ E-tender Notice No.

: TNWB_Renovation_2026
dt.24.02.2026

➤ Tender publish date in

: 24.02.2026 at 10.00 A.M.
<http://tntenders.gov.in> portal through online

➤ Bid Submission Closing date in

: 05.03.2026 at 06.00 P.M.

➤ Bid Opening Date

: 06.03.2026 at 3.00 PM

➤ Downloading the tender document

: From 24.02.2026 to 06.03.2026
upto 02.00 P.M. by Free of Cost

➤ For further details visit website

: <http://tntenders.gov.in>

CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER,

TAMILNADU WAQF BOARD, CHENNAI-600 001

IPRO/08/CHENNAI/2026/DATE : 23.02.2026

TAMILNADU WAQF BOARD, CHENNAI-600 001

CENTRAL RAILWAY

REPAIR AND MAINTENANCE WORKS

Open e-tender notice No.CR-DRM(W)BB-2026-09 of 20.02.2026

Sr.No.1. Name of work: A) Painting and repairs to station FOB'S of CSMT station FOB connecting PF No. 1 to 7 at km 0.250, SNRD station FOB km 2.050 and Sewri station CSMT end FOB at km 6.884 total 03 Nos. FOBs between CSMT-VDLR section with Zinc rich primer, MIO coat and PU painting scheme to steel structure. B) Replacement of inspection damaged/wornout board to FOB's /ROB's / Pipeline Bridge & Provision by Bridge Board to FOB's & Pipeline Bridge in the BY-VK section over main Line & KCE-MNKD section over HB line. C) Repairs, Provision of OHE protective screen & protective painting to Trombay Line ROB at km. 19/18A-19B between CLA-TMBY Line. Approximate Value: ₹108.89 lakhs. EMD: ₹2,04,500/-. Completion period :12 months.

Sr.No.2. Name of work: CLA- Miscellaneous annual maintenance work at station areas, platforms and service building in lieu of zone under SSE(W)CLA for year 2025-26. Approximate Value: ₹106.29 Lakhs. EMD: ₹2,03,200/- . Completion period: 12 months.

Sr.No.3. Name of work: A) Miscellaneous P.Way work for SSE (P.Way) VSD for 2026 under ADEN(NE)KYN. B) Miscellaneous P.Way work for SSE (P.Way) KYN East Section under ADEN (NE)KYN for the FY 2026-27. Approximate Value: ₹308.39 Lakhs. EMD: ₹3,04,200/- . Completion period: 12 months.

Sr.No.4. Name of work: A) Miscellaneous P.Way work for SSE(P/Way) KSRA; B) Miscellaneous P.Way work for SSE(P/Way) IGP for the FY 2026-27 under Sr DEN(NE) CSMT. Approximate Value: ₹316.12 Lakhs. EMD: ₹3,08,100/- . Completion period: 12 months.

Sr.No.5. Name of work: (A) Improvement to Vasingd & Asangoan Yard under SSE P.Way VSD; (B) Improvement to Titwala & Khadvali Yard under SSE P.Way VSD. Approximate Value: ₹162.27 Lakhs. EMD: ₹2,31,100/- . Completion period: 8 months.

Sr.No.6. Name of work: (A) Igatpuri Yard Improvement for year 2026; (B) Titoli Yard Improvement under Sr DEN (NE) section. Approximate Value: ₹127.44 Lakhs. EMD: ₹2,13,700/- . Completion period: 8 months.

Sr.No.7. Name of work: A) Repairs to Diesel Shed including leaky roof, replacement of small size valley gutter, repairs to damaged road at Kalyan Diesel Shed, under ADEN(W)KYN. B) Proposal of G+2 service building for replacement of indoor and outdoor signalling gears of DCC cabin with electronic interlocking at DCC. C) Repairs to service buildings, external & internal painting at Kaman Road, Kharbav, Bhivandi Road and Juchandra stations under ADEN(W)KYN. Approximate Value: ₹554.77 Lakhs. EMD: ₹4,27,400/- . Completion period: 12 months.

Sr.No.8. Name of work: A) Improvement to existing boundary wall of Kurla railway colony. B) Repairs to road at Kurla Railway colony under ADEN(Wks)BY. C) Repairs to drainage line at Kurla Railway Colony under ADEN(Wks)BY. D) VVH - Repairs to approach road, side drain, pathway of building, plinth protection of bldg. at VVH Colony under SSE(Wks)CLA under ADEN(W)BY. Approximate Value: ₹660.50 Lakhs. EMD: ₹4,80,300/- . Completion period: 12 months.

I) Tender closing date & time of aforesaid tender: Up-to 15:00 hrs. of Sr.No.1 on 19.03.2026, Sr.No.2,3 and 4 on 10.03.2026, Sr.No. 5 and 6 on 13.03.2026, and Sr.No.7 and 8 on 17.03.2026 to be opened after 15:00 hrs.

II) The prospective tenderers are requested to visit the website www.ireps.gov.in for details of tenders & corrigendum, if any.

III) Tenderer may participate in above e-tender electronically through website www.ireps.gov.in only & submission of manual offers against e-tender are not allowed. Manually, if submitted shall neither be opened nor considered.

IV) The Bid Security shall be deposited either in cash through e-payment gateway or submitted as Bank Guarantee bond from a scheduled commercial bank of India or as mentioned in tender documents.

V) For further enquiry, may contact: Divisional Railway Manager (Works) Office, Central Railway on phone. 022-67455323.

VI) This tender complies with Public Procurement Policy Order 2017 dated 16.9.2017.

Complete details of tenders are available at the website "www.ireps.gov.in". The complete details of tenders are also available in the "Notice Board" of the Divisional Railway Manager (Works) Office, Mumbai CSMT.

AK-924

Unsafe and unauthorized work near the railway line is a punishable offence



भारत सरकार GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

श्री राम मनोहर लोहिया अस्पताल.

अटल बिहारी वाजपेयी आसुविज्ञान संस्थान. नई दिल्ली

DR. RAM MANOHAR LOHIA HOSPITAL

ATAL BIHARI VAJPAYEE INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES

NEW DELHI -110001

No.HA-II-11022/1/2023-HA-II Section-Dr. RMLH/594
16/02/2026

Recruitment Notice for the post of Senior Resident (Regular Basis)

The Medical Superintendent, Dr. Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital & ABVIMS, New Delhi invites applications from Indian National in the prescribed form available on web-site [rmlh\(dot\)nic\(dot\)in](http://rmlh(dot)nic(dot)in) for the posts of Senior Resident (Non-Academic) on regular basis.

The detailed advertisement, numbers of posts, eligibility conditions, pay structure, age criteria, application form and other details can be seen in the full advertisement on the website www.rmlh.nic.in. Any corrigendum/ modification order regarding this advertisement will be issued on the hospital website only. Candidates are advised to visit hospital website www.rmlh.nic.in regularly for this purpose. Last date for submission of application is 10/03/2026 till 03-00 p.m.

Officer-in-charge
HA-II Section

CBC 17147/11/0011/2526



Government of Karnataka

FOOD, CIVIL SUPPLIES & CONSUMER AFFAIRS DEPARTMENT

(Procurement and Distribution Section)

8, Cunningham Road, 4th Floor, Sahakara Bhavan,
Bengaluru-560052.

Website: www.ahara.kar.nic.in & www.neml.in
e-mail: indirafoodkit@gmail.com

No. 1/2025-26/ComFCS/IFK

Date:23.02.2026

CORRIGENDUM-2

CORRIGENDUM FOR EXTENSION OF DATE FOR SUBMISSION OF TECHNICAL BID FOR PROCUREMENT OF FOOD MATERIALS-TUR DAL, SUNFLOWER OIL, SUGAR AND IODIZED SALT UNDER ANNA BHAGYA SCHEME OF THE GOVERNMENT OF KARNATAKA THROUGH E-AUCTION.

The Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs Department, Bengaluru, Government of Karnataka with reference to the earlier notification regarding submission of documents for the INDIRA Ahara Kit published on 23.01.2026, it is informed to all concerned that the last date for the submission of Technical Bid has been extended. The date of submission of Technical Bids which was previously fixed as 23.02.2026 till 5:30 P.M. has been extended to 02.03.2026 till 5:30 P.M. The details of which will be uploaded in the website: www.neml.in.

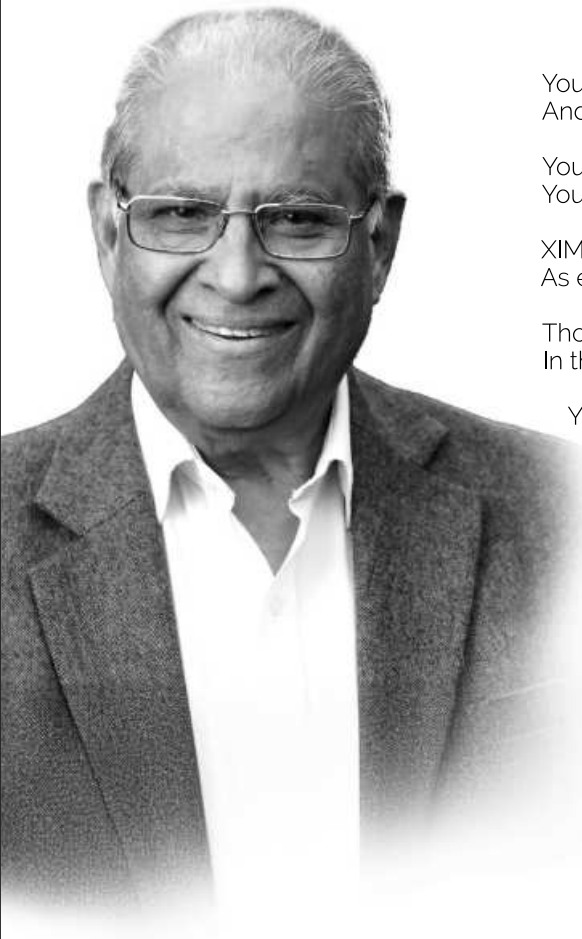
For further information, if any, please contact NCDEX e Markets Ltd Toll-Free No. 1800-210-1222 or e-mail at askus@neml.in.

Sd/- Commissioner,
Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs Department

Chevalier Prof. J Philip

21 May 1936 - 21 Feb 2026

You Chose A Higher Calling



You saw promise in young minds.
And made it your mission to shape them.

You built more than institutions.
You built ideals. Value by value.

XIME and XIS stand today,
As enduring symbols of your vision.

Thousands carry your imprint.
In their careers. And in their character.

You didn't just raise the bar for education.
You defined it.

You are, and always will be,
A legend. A light. A lasting legacy.

Rest in peace, Dear Sir.

Viewing

24 February 2026 | 9:00 AM – 11:00 AM
Xavier Institute of Management & Entrepreneurship, Hosur Road, Phase II,
Electronic City, Bengaluru, Karnataka 560100

Funeral service

24 February 2026
Funeral Mass | St. Anthony's Friary Church,
Hosur Road | 2:00 pm
Burial | St. Patrick's Cemetery

 XIS
INTERNATIONAL
SCHOOL
Inspired Learning

 XIME
Shaping Future Leaders
Bangalore | Kochi | Chennai

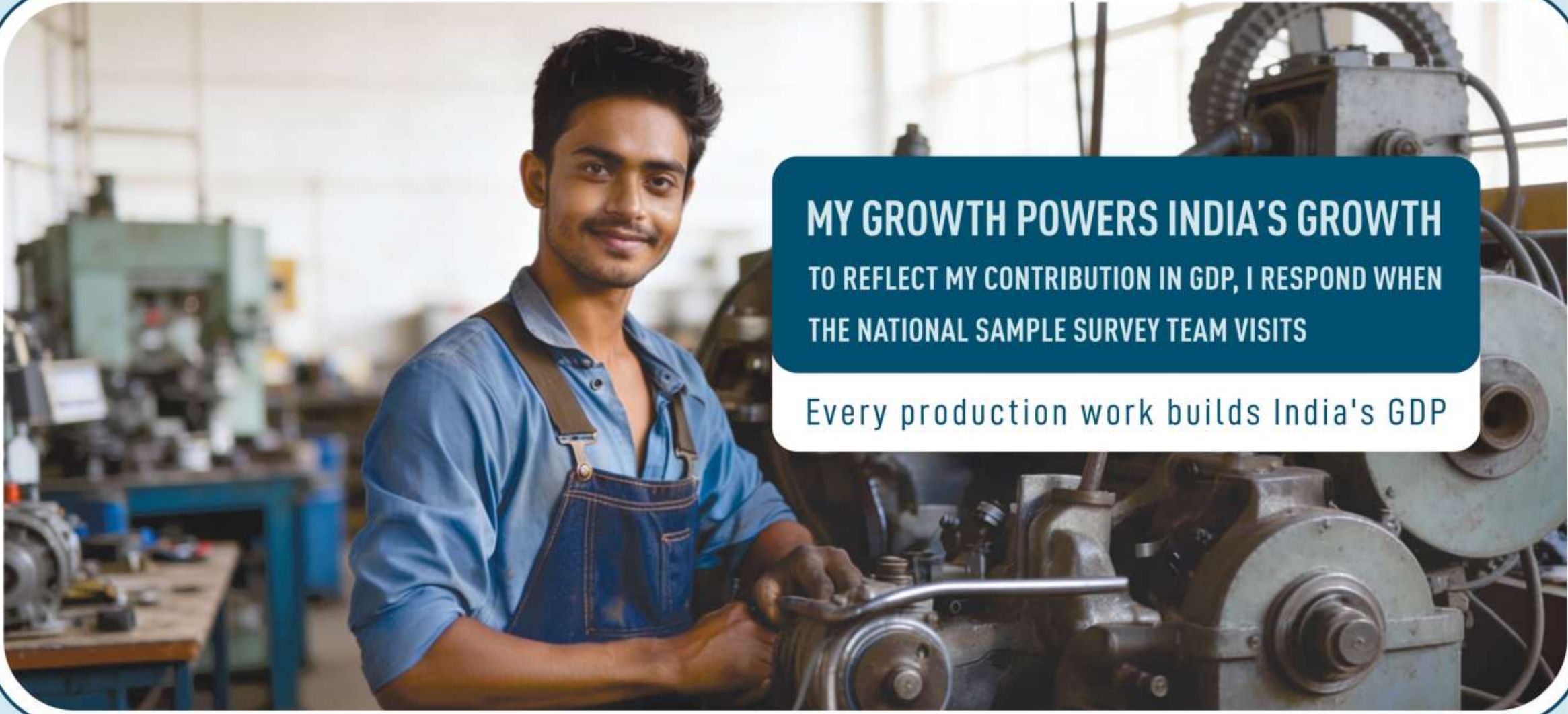


Government of India

Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation



DATA FOR DEVELOPMENT



MY GROWTH POWERS INDIA'S GROWTH
TO REFLECT MY CONTRIBUTION IN GDP, I RESPOND WHEN
THE NATIONAL SAMPLE SURVEY TEAM VISITS

Every production work builds India's GDP

UPDATING GDP BASE YEAR TO 2022-23:

• INCORPORATING NEW DATA SOURCES • IMPROVED METHODOLOGY • FOR BETTER DATA BASED DECISION MAKING

Release Date: 27 February 2026

Please cooperate with NSO enumerators when they come for survey. Your identity will be kept confidential.

 mospi.gov.in    @GoIStats  /goistats  GoIStats  Ministry of Statistics & PI

CBC 39101/13/0010/2526

M CH-CHE

INBRIEF



CPI leader Nallakannu's health deteriorates, CM visits hospital

The health of veteran leader of the Communist Party of India (CPI) R. Nallakannu deteriorated, as he continued to receive medical treatment at the Rajiv Gandhi Government General Hospital in Chennai on Monday. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin visited the hospital and enquired about the leader's health with his family members and doctors. Ministers Thangam Thennarasu and P.K. Sekarbabu and CPI State secretary M. Veerapandian were present during the Chief Minister's visit. Earlier in the day, Mr. Veerapandian told reporters the veteran leader had been admitted to the hospital for the past 20 days. "As of now, his health is declining," he said.

50 companies of CAPF to be allotted to the State for polls

Fifty companies of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) have been initially allotted to Tamil Nadu by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs for the Assembly election, Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik said on Monday. "The initial 50 companies of CAPF will be inducted on March 10 to Tamil Nadu," the officer said.

As Congress pushes for more seats, DMK hints at retaining '25 + 1 formula'

B. Kolappan
Udhav Naig
CHENNAI

The ruling DMK and the Congress were unable to come to a preliminary understanding on the number of seats the latter would contest in the upcoming Assembly election in Tamil Nadu, before they could begin formal seat-sharing talks on February 26 or 27.

"The Congress is expecting more than 30 Assembly seats but the DMK is not willing to allot more than 25 and one Rajya Sabha seat," a source in the DMK said. The original demand of the Congress was one Assembly seat for every Lok Sabha seat in Tamil Nadu, which is 39. Though it has reduced its demand, it remains firm on getting more than 30. A senior Congress leader, however, claimed that the party high command had pitched for 41 seats, 25% representation for Congress in local bodies, and appointments as trustees in Temple Boards as part of the negotiations. Besides, it expected the DMK to consider accommodating its representative in the Ca-

binet during government formation, post-polls. According to this leader, the party has also sought two Rajya Sabha berths.

On Monday, All India Congress Committee in-charge of Tamil Nadu Girish Chodankar and TNCC president K. Selvaperunthagai met DMK Parliamentary party leader Kanimozhi and discussed the issue. This followed Sunday's meeting between DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and AICC general secretary K.C. Venugopal in Chennai. "What has caused the stalemate is the Congress's insistence on getting more than 30 Assembly seats," the DMK source said.

Mr. Chodankar, after meeting Ms. Kanimozhi, also acknowledged that talks remained inconclusive though the discussion on the Rajya Sabha seats and the local body elections went "positively". He said the seat-sharing committees of the two parties would meet and iron out the issue. "We are waiting for the date," he said.

Sources in Congress said its demands had reportedly been laid out in a letter from party leader Sonia

Gandhi, which was handed over to Mr. Stalin by the Congress delegation. "It has been communicated that we will not raise the issue of share in power in public until the elections are over. But, we have insisted on share in power," said a Congress leader, privy to the development.

MMK, MDMK hold talks
Earlier in the day, Manitha-neya Makkal Katchi (MMK) held talks with the DMK's seat-sharing committee at Anna Arivalayam. M.H. Jawahirullah, the party's leader and MLA, said the MMK had in 2021 contested two seats – Papanasam and Manapparai – and won both. "Our party has roots in all districts. This time, we have sought five seats. The committee told us our demand would be brought to the notice of Mr. Stalin," he said.

Mr. Jawahirullah added that as in the previous election, his party would contest on the 'rising sun' symbol of the DMK. Leaders of Vaiko's Marumalarchi Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (MDMK) also held talks with the DMK seat-sharing committee headed by party treasurer T.R. Baalu.

Sri Lankan Navy arrests 12 fishermen from Pamban

The Hindu Bureau
RAMESWARAM

The Sri Lankan Navy arrested 12 fishermen of Pamban and impounded a mechanised trawler on the charge of poaching in the Palk Strait in the early hours of Monday.

According to officials of the Fisheries Department, the trawler, owned by David of Pamban, was seized with the 12 fishermen on board. They were detained while fishing between Katchatheevu and Mannar. The fishermen put out to sea on Sunday, and were expected to return to the shore around noon Monday. After preliminary interrogation, they were taken to the naval port at

Talaimannar, officials added.

Condemning the arrest, fishermen leader Jesu Raja said only last week were 22 fishermen arrested and four trawlers impounded by the Sri Lankan Navy. "With just a few days left for the festival at St. Antony's Church on Katchatheevu, such incidents have created disharmony among the fisherfolk," he said. He said though the Sri Lankan authorities had invited pilgrims from India to the two-day Katchatheevu festival, such incidents caused mental agony. "We are unsure whether to accept the invitation and take part in the festival or stay back," he said.

Following a recent court



The arrested fishermen have been taken to the naval port in Talaimannar in Sri Lanka.

directive to release six trawlers, around 10 fishermen of Rameswaram travelled to Sri Lanka a few days ago, hoping to retrieve their boats.

However, while they were waiting in the court hall, officials reportedly said the boat-owners would also be booked on the charge of poaching. The fishermen-leaders and

boat owners returned home empty-handed two days ago.

Narrating the ordeal, Mr. Raja said the Union government's intervention was the only way to achieve a permanent solution. A boat owner alleged that advocates in Sri Lanka were unwilling to represent them in court. "As a result, we were unable to obtain any legal relief. Only if the Union government issues directions to officials at the Indian High Commission in Sri Lanka will the matters move in our favour," he said.

CM writes to Jaishankar
Chief Minister M.K. Stalin wrote to Minister for External Affairs S. Jaishankar, re-



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin speaking at the event in Chennai on Monday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Mr. Stalin further alleged, "In fact, they [the BJP government] have been preventing the registration of FIRs against some former Ministers through the Governor for long. Now, they are trying to threaten us with the ED, the Income Tax Department, and the CBI. Even if the BJP brings its forces..., we are very well prepared to face them."

Questioning how many of the 8,000-odd cases registered by the ED had been fully investigated and the agency's rate of conviction,

Mr. Stalin said, "Those against whom corruption charges are framed are joining hands with whom? The BJP is undertaking political witch-hunting by pettily using the investigation agencies. And they have named it the NDA."

Later, at an interview, asked whether there would be a multi-cornered contest in the coming Tamil Nadu Assembly election, Mr. Stalin said, "Certainly, there may be a multi-cornered contest. But they are not strong enough."

We are prepared to face ED, I-T Dept., and CBI, says Stalin

The BJP-led government at the Centre has been preventing the registration of FIRs related to corruption charges against some ex-Ministers through the Governor, the Chief Minister alleges

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

If the BJP brings in "its forces" in the form of the Enforcement Directorate (ED), the Income Tax Department, and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), "we are very well prepared to face them," DMK president and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin said in Chennai on Monday.

He also accused the BJP of using the investigation agencies to further its political ambitions.

Speaking at the *CNN News 18's* Town Hall event, he said, "The NDA [National Democratic Alliance] is an alliance that has been formed by threatening the corrupt. Many who were Ministers of the AIADMK government were raided. Cases filed by the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) are still pending against about 10 of them. The BJP is protecting them because of the alliance."

Replying to a question on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visits to Tamil Nadu recently and the BJP's efforts to ensure the victory of its alliance, Mr. Stalin said, "As I keep repeating, the Prime Minister should visit often. [Union Home Minister] Amit Shah should keep visiting, too. This Governor [R.N. Ravi] should not be replaced."

'Aware of my stature'

Asked about voices appealing to him to head the INDIA bloc, Mr. Stalin recalled the observations made by late leader and former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi that he was well aware of his stature. "Thalaivar said he was aware of his stature. I, too, will act according to my stature." Referring to an article he had penned in *The Hindu* that India's federalism was in need of a structural reset, Mr. Stalin said an understanding at the national level on the issue was necessary.

Vijay rejects Stalin's 'T.N. vs Delhi' remark, says fight is between his party and DMK

The Hindu Bureau
VELLORE

Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) founder and actor Vijay on Monday rejected Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's claim that the 2026 Assembly election would be a contest between "Tamil Nadu and New Delhi". He asserted that the real fight would be between the TVK and the ruling DMK.

Addressing TVK office-bearers and functionaries at a conference held at Agaramcheri near the Pallikonda toll-plaza in Vellore, Mr. Vijay was referring to Mr. Stalin's recent remarks that the 2026 election would be a fight between the people of Tamil Nadu and the BJP-led Centre in New Delhi over the protection of the State's rights.

In other words, Mr. Vijay said, the contest was being projected as one between the people of Tamil Nadu and the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), of which the BJP is a constituent in the State. "It does



TVK president Vijay addressing a meeting in Vellore on Monday. C. VENKATACHALAPATHY

not sound logical. The 2026 Assembly election is a battle between the people of Tamil Nadu and corruption. In short, it is a fight between the 'clean force' led by the TVK and the 'evil force' that is the DMK," he said.

Mr. Vijay cautioned voters, especially the youth, against making light of this election. He said such a fiercely contested election would happen only once in 50 years, not every five years. "When you vote in this election, you should remember that one of the contestants is your family member. We are inseparable," he said.

Sholinganallur continues to have the highest number of electors

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Electorate round-up				
District-wise list of voters in T.N. (as on February 23, 2026)				
District	Men	Women	Third gender	Total
Tiruvallur	15,44,710	16,12,090	613	31,57,413
Chennai	13,65,763	14,64,344	829	28,30,936
Kancheepuram	5,78,080	6,13,917	197	11,92,194
Vellore	5,49,654	5,83,769	164	11,33,587
Krishnagiri	7,76,318	7,77,458	264	15,54,040
Dharmapuri	6,24,647	6,15,311	150	12,40,108
Tiruvannamalai	9,43,727	9,75,277	155	19,19,159
Villupuram	7,83,288	8,03,154	211	15,86,653
Salem	13,70,962	13,84,548	320	27,55,830
Namakkal	6,35,299	6,75,452	200	13,10,951
Erode	8,38,466	9,01,574	182	17,40,222
The Nilgiris	2,61,317	2,85,791	25	5,47,133
Coimbatore	13,00,889	13,95,396	528	26,96,813
Dindigul	8,12,937	8,58,964	174	16,72,075
Karur	4,06,027	4,39,054	83	8,45,164
Tiruchi	10,31,354	10,94,642	307	2,126,303
Perambalur	2,71,634	2,83,466	31	5,55,131
Cuddalore	9,91,527	10,23,976	293	20,15,796
Nagapattinam	2,59,620	2,68,298	29	5,27,947
Tiruvarur	4,80,679	4,98,919	54	9,79,652
Thanjavur	9,47,278	10,04,012	155	19,51,445
Pudukottai	6,41,276	6,57,562	69	12,98,907
Sivaganga	5,44,035	5,66,526	38	11,10,599
Madurai	12,08,651	12,58,051	252	24,66,954
Theni	5,02,311	5,30,887	175	10,33,373
Virudhunagar	7,28,539	7,68,632	246	14,97,417
Ramanathapuram	5,56,321	5,66,653	55	11,23,029
Thoothukudi	6,71,742	7,04,689	193	13,76,624
Tirunelveli	6,11,601	6,41,518	145	12,53,264
Kanniyakumari	7,51,016	7,59,390	144	15,10,550
Ariyalur	2,59,234	2,63,692	28	5,22,954
Tiruppur	9,44,178	10,10,853	252	19,55,283
Kallakurichi	5,52,101	5,57,600	210	11,09,911
Tenkasi	6,18,063	6,46,180	168	12,64,411
Chengalpattu	11,04,511	11,55,144	381	22,60,036
Tirupattur	4,49,464	4,61,996	139	9,11,599
Ranipet	4,61,213	4,83,377	111	9,44,701
Mayiladuthurai	3,60,493	3,68,676	47	7,29,216
Total	2,77,38,925	2,89,60,838	7,617	5,67,07,380

"Even now, you could submit Form 6 for inclusion or forms if you want any changes. Appeal, if any, could also be made now," said Ms. Patnaik. The first appeal could be filed with the District Election Officer and the second appeal could be filed with the Chief Electoral Officer. For inclusion, one could submit Form 6 to the Booth Level Officers (BLOs) or apply online.

There is no change in the number of polling booths, which remains at 75,032. During the claims and objections period, about 7.40 lakh people in the 18-19 age group were included, she said. To a question on the possible deletion of entries from the final rolls, Ms. Patnaik said, "Continuous update is ongoing." As for Form 8, Ms. Patnaik said 3,400 applications were received and 3,351 were disposed of.

Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar will visit the State on February 26 and 27. Ms. Patnaik said he would meet the District Election Officers and the Superintendents of Police concerned, the Commissioners of Police, the Inspectors-General of Police, officials of 23 enforcement agencies, and representatives of political parties.

State Cabinet approves incentives for 46 projects

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A meeting of the Tamil Nadu Cabinet headed by Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Monday approved incentives for 46 industrial projects with investments to the tune of ₹31,592 crore.

These investment proposals are expected to come up in 16 districts and are expected to generate employment for over 61,000 people, Minister for Industries T.R.B. Rajaa said.

Briefing journalists after the Cabinet meeting, Mr. Rajaa said among the investors are Sakthi Aircraft Industry, NMB-Minebea, Yield Engineering Systems, Dixon, SFO Technologies, Vikram Solar, Minerva's Special Purpose Vehicle, Hikoki Power Tools, Festo, Aequs, Schneider Electric, Bharat Biotech, Caterpillar Inc., Boeing, and Saint Gobain.

Incentives have also been approved for investment proposals from M2P Fintech, HD Supply, Ford, Flextronics, Adidas, Bella-Premier, and LMW. Mr. Rajaa said the DMK government was focusing on distributed development across the State.

Panel for Union-State relations deliberates on Part-II of report

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government-constituted high-level committee for Union-State relations, which submitted Part I of its report to Chief Minister M.K. Stalin earlier this month, met in New Delhi on Sunday to deliberate on Part II of its report.

Justice Kurian Joseph, the committee's Chairperson and former Judge of the Supreme Court and its members M. Naganathan, former Vice-Chairman of the State Planning Commission, and K. Ashok Vardhan Shetty, retired IAS

officer, discussed various topics to be included in Part II of its report, covering 10 chapters, an official release said.

Part I of the report – in Tamil and English – was tabled in the Assembly on February 16. It covered 10 key topics ranging from language policy to the Governor, education, health, delimitation, elections, and Goods and Services Tax, among others. "A notable feature is that the Tamil version of the report has been made 'open access' so that anyone can publish it, either in its entirety or in part, provided that the source is duly acknowledged and no changes of any kind are made. This is to ensure that the ideas and recommendations of the Committee are disseminated widely," it said.

multiple translations

The Tamil Nadu government has also proposed to release the first part of the report in Assamese, Bengali, Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Odia, Punjabi, and Telugu, and make them "open access" too. In April 2025, the State government constituted the committee "as a non-partisan exercise," and it commenced work on June 1 that year.

Editorial



AI for all

The AI Impact Summit was a sign of things to come in India

The attendance at the AI Impact Summit, in New Delhi, showed an extreme enthusiasm for Artificial Intelligence (AI) technologies by digitally connected Indians. While statistics shared by AI firms have frequently cited India as the biggest user base outside the U.S., the crowds over the week were the biggest indicator of just how keen many Indians are to adopt this technology. At its core, the summit was a continuation of a series of annual multilateral discussions on AI, and 89 countries have signed a declaration laying out a voluntary set of commitments to share knowledge on AI democratisation. The summit's context comes with foreboding challenges for India: namely, deploying and diffusing a technology whose capital and infrastructure reside abroad, and finding a place in the global AI ecosystem that will place Indians well in the economic transformations that this technology's adoption promises. India's data centre capacity is growing healthily, but the AI moment calls for further momentum, a difficult ask when the costs of graphics processing units (GPUs) driving AI push up the cost of domestic deployment so much, not to mention the additional electrical capacity that must be built. A national strategy that relies overwhelmingly on becoming a hub for the deployment of models, with less emphasis on their training and finetuning, could pose risks; after all, with fewer labour costs, the advantage that India has will be smaller than in the ITes era.

On the international cooperation front, it is disappointing that India has so eagerly enabled the U.S.'s hands-off impulses for AI. This is a technology with enormous scope for economic and social disruption. Countries must use the annual AI forum to collectively build tools and safety standards that can exercise actual leverage over how LLMs diffuse throughout society. Leadership of the Global South entails empowering countries that are individually vulnerable to collateral damage in an era of great power rivalries. AI is increasingly defining that era more and more acutely. Consensus at all costs is not the appropriate approach. As a country of enthusiastic AI adopters, India has the leverage and capacity to articulate an optimistic but prudent way forward for AI governance, and the summit declaration showed no signs of this power. The summit's central pillar remains an important one: for AI to be a net good, its capabilities need to be democratised. As India closes its digital divide, there cannot be an inference gap. If the summit made anything clear, it was that India is as capable of organically contributing to worldwide growth as it has the capacity, should it choose, to be a force to shape its orderly growth.

Stick together

India and Brazil have realised the importance of their groupings

Brazilian President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva's India visit last week sent important messages for both India-Brazil ties, and for solidarity in the developing world, as two Global South powers focused on global governance and leadership. After his talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India and Brazil agreed to try and double trade to \$30 billion by 2030, and signed agreements on critical minerals, steel mining, and digital cooperation to diversify beyond China-led supply chains. Mr. Lula, along with French President Emmanuel Macron, was among about 20 leaders at India's AI Impact Summit and was later accorded a state visit. The 80-year-old Brazilian President's presence was important, as he faces elections later this year, which may make it difficult for him to attend India's BRICS summit if it coincides with his campaigning for a fourth term. It also came amidst fresh turmoil over U.S.-imposed trade tariffs, after the American Supreme Court struck down U.S. President Donald Trump's rationale for the reciprocal tariffs. India and Brazil were both the highest taxed countries by the U.S. – 50% tariffs each – and both faced further possible tariffs over BRICS ties, Iran trade, and Russian oil imports. India and Brazil are also key members of the BRICS grouping of developing nations, the India-Brazil-South Africa (IBSA), G-4 with Germany and South Africa on UNSC reform, and co-founders of the biofuel alliance for alternative energy; each of these has faced challenges from Mr. Trump's policies on trade, territorial sovereignty, multilateralism and the UN, and fossil fuels. Amid such uncertainty, Mr. Modi and Mr. Lula reaffirmed their commitment to protecting the multilateral order.

Before leaving India, Mr. Lula, who is set to visit Washington next month, did not mince words while speaking to journalists about the challenges posed by the U.S. government. As a former trade union leader, he said he believed that the only way of tackling geopolitical uncertainty unleashed by the U.S. was for countries to “un-ionise”, rather than cutting deals individually with Washington, which leave smaller nations at a disadvantage. The words are particularly important for both Delhi and Brasilia, as both have negotiated with the Trump administration on tariffs, but have not so far signed trade deals with the U.S. The U.S. court ruling offers an opportunity to reset the terms of the agreements, and it is significant that New Delhi has postponed a meeting of trade negotiators this week to give the U.S. and India time to assess the ruling. India and Brazil, and their developing world partners, should coordinate the next steps and stay engaged with Washington. Mr. Lula's warning is clear: it is easy to break a single stick, but far more difficult to do so if the sticks are bundled tightly together.

The passing of three adolescent girls in Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, earlier this month, is a case that deeply unsettled the public. The intense media attention reflects collective grief – but treating this tragedy as an isolated incident risks ignoring a larger reality. India faces a growing, largely neglected crisis in child and adolescent mental health, rooted in early vulnerability and worsened by an unregulated digital environment.

Mental health challenges are no longer limited to adults or older teens. Clinicians increasingly see anxiety, depression, attention disorders and behavioural issues in much younger children. Yet, many families, schools and even parts of the health-care system still view these as “adult issues”. In fact, emotional and behavioural disorders can appear as early as four or five years of age. Early trauma, neglect and chronic stress can disrupt emotional and cognitive development, often resurfacing with greater intensity during adolescence.

These conditions have also grown more complex. Where children showed a single diagnosis, comorbidities are now common – attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD) with anxiety, depression with compulsive digital use, learning difficulties with emotional distress—making early recognition crucial.

The extent of the problem

Population-level data mirrors what clinicians observe daily. Findings from the National Mental Health Survey and subsequent studies suggest that between seven per cent to 10% of Indian adolescents have diagnosable mental health conditions, and five per cent to seven per cent of school-aged children have ADHD. Yet early signs – withdrawal, impulsivity, sudden behavioural changes – are often dismissed, leading to academic, social and long-term emotional harm. India faces an acute shortage of trained child and adolescent mental health professionals. With fewer than 10,000 psychiatrists for a population exceeding 1.4 billion—and only a small fraction specialising in child mental health – the gap is stark. Shortages of clinical psychologists, child psychologists and psychiatric social workers further strain an already fragile system. Families are left to navigate fragmented care largely on their own.

Childhood vulnerability has been amplified by a transformed digital landscape. The rise in mental health concerns parallels the spread of smartphones and low-priced Internet data, now used by over 800 million Indians—many of them children. The COVID-19 pandemic further embedded screens into daily life including education, recreation and social interaction.

With schoolwork, communication and entertainment all on the same device, boundaries have blurred. Internet addiction which is marked by loss of control, irritability, sleep disruption and social withdrawal, is now a routine clinical concern.

As early as 2019, the World Health



Dr. Chandrakant Lahariya

is a practising cardio-metabolic physician, health policy expert and a specialist in parenting and child development



Dr. Deepak Gupta

is a leading child and adolescent psychiatrist

Families, schools and policymakers must prioritise youth mental wellbeing

Organization issued guidelines and had cautioned against excessive screen exposure among children and adolescents, highlighting its adverse effects on sleep, attention, emotional regulation and overall wellbeing. These recommendations predated the pandemic. It is important to understand that the excessive screen use does not cause neurodevelopmental conditions such as ADHD or autism spectrum disorders. However, it can significantly exacerbate symptoms, delay diagnosis and displace the human interaction essential for healthy brain development during periods of heightened neuroplasticity. In vulnerable children, this displacement can have lasting consequences.

Against this backdrop, parents and families have to assume a central role. They are not merely caregivers but a child's first mental health buffer – as the earliest observers of emotional change and the most consistent source of psychological safety. Trauma-informed parenting, which recognises how stress, loss and adversity shape behaviour, must extend beyond clinical settings into everyday life. Listening without judgement, noticing changes in sleep, mood or social engagement, and seeking help early can dramatically alter outcomes.

Support groups are proven to further strengthen this protective environment. Parent support groups reduce isolation, normalise help-seeking and enable shared learning. Adolescent peer-support groups provide safe spaces for emotional expression, resilience-building and the development of coping skills. Evidence consistently shows that such collective, community-based approaches are more effective than isolated, clinic-centred interventions.

Schools are a weak link

Schools, however, remain a critical weak link. Academic performance continues to dominate institutional priorities, often at the expense of emotional wellbeing. Examinations, rankings and competition define school culture, while structured attention to emotional regulation, stress management and happiness remains limited. This imbalance is neither benign nor sustainable. Mental wellbeing is foundational to learning, creativity and long-term productivity; without it, academic success is fragile and transient.

A further challenge lies in the gap between evidence and practice. India's research base on child and adolescent mental health, digital behaviour and early intervention has grown steadily. Yet, translation into routine care remains slow. Paediatricians – often the first point of contact for families – must routinely inquire about emotional wellbeing, sleep patterns, screen use and peer relationships, and not just physical growth. Teachers, counsellors, psychologists and all professionals working with children need structured training to identify early signs of mental health problems and Internet-related harms. Stigma continues to delay care, with

India's energy shift through the green ammonia route

At the inaugural session of the India Energy Week (IEW), in January 2026, Prime Minister Narendra Modi positioned India's ambitions at the centrestage of the global energy discourse, highlighting investment opportunities worth \$500 billion across the sector. As India raises its ambition from energy security to energy independence, the affordability of clean energy such as green hydrogen and its derivatives is critical to the long-term competitiveness of India's energy transition. But from fertilizers to clean energy and marine fuel, there are now green ammonia applications which are wide-ranging. Green ammonia – produced by combining nitrogen with green hydrogen – is currently leading in the adoption of green hydrogen, with its strategic adoption advanced across regions such as the European Union (EU), India and South Korea.

Aggregated procurement mechanisms are starting to lay the foundation for a global green ammonia market. Some noteworthy examples include H2Global's tender of green ammonia under the EU's hydrogen import strategy, South Korea's Clean Hydrogen Portfolio Standard (CHPS) tender for clean ammonia procurement as a bulk fuel, and the recent tender concluded by the Solar Energy Corporation of India (SECI) under the Strategic Interventions for Green Hydrogen Transition (SIGHT) programme of India's National Green Hydrogen Mission.

Green ammonia auction

Compared to these global procurement practices, India's green ammonia auction under SECI demonstrates broader market participation, attracting 15 bidders and resulting in seven unique successful awardees. Under the SIGHT programme, SECI floated a tender in June 2024 for an aggregated demand of up to 724,000 tonnes of green ammonia annually across 13 fertilizer plants in India. These tenders concluded

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The country's green ammonia auction model has the potential to redefine global standards for clean energy adoption

in August 2025, and offered a 10-year, fixed-price offtake agreements to successful bidders. This clarity in price and offtake provided producers with the market certainty required for investment. The auctions established a significant breakthrough in cost-competitive green ammonia procurement, setting new global benchmarks, almost 40%-50% less than the prices from the H2Global auction

The tender process faced multiple extensions and revisions, primarily to resolve concerns around risk allocation, payment security, and clarity on offtake and pricing conditions, raised by both project developers and offtakers. These refinements successfully addressed concerns, leading to a balanced win-win framework for all stakeholders.

In this auction, seven bidders secured a total of 13 delivery contracts for green ammonia. Notably, one company won six contracts for 3,70,000 tonnes/year. These contracts include production subsidies of ₹8.82 a kilogramme, ₹7.06 a kg, and ₹5.3 a kg for the first three years and a 10-year fixed price supply agreement to existing fertilizer manufacturers in India.

The discovered prices of green ammonia across these tenders range from ₹49.75 and ₹64.74/kg (\$572 and \$744 a tonne). In India, the grey ammonia price is as high as \$515 a tonne. When factoring in the newly discovered price of green ammonia, supported by longer-term contracts, the cost gap has significantly narrowed.

On delivery and transportation

Notably, a standout feature of SECI's tender is the pre-identification of delivery points, as most fertilizer plants where the green ammonia is to be delivered are located near coastal areas, enabling the transportation of green ammonia through shipping as well. The contracted volumes of green ammonia contribute to approximately 30%

families often seeking help only during crises.

In today's context, child and adolescent mental health is intricately linked to social media and Internet use. These concerns were explicitly acknowledged in India's Economic Survey 2025-26, released in January 2026, which highlighted rising mental health challenges among young people and proposed a range of preventive strategies. Several Indian States, drawing on precedents in Australia, France and South Korea, are considering regulatory steps to limit adolescent social media use. This is an idea whose time has come, provided it is implemented thoughtfully, alongside education and support rather than punitive controls.

Actions to implement

Policy and programmatic action must now align with reality. India can strengthen existing platforms – the National Mental Health Programme, school health services under Ayushman Bharat – health and wellness centre initiative, and tele-mental health initiatives – by introducing routine school-based screening, training teachers and frontline workers in early identification of child and adolescent mental health issues, and reinforcing referral pathways. Earmarked funding for child mental health initiatives, clear guidelines on digital use in schools, and affordable community-based counselling, especially for low- and middle-income families, are urgently needed.

Implementation, however, faces practical hurdles. Stigma surrounding mental health remains pervasive, and child psychiatry carries an even heavier burden of fear and misunderstanding. Concerns about labelling, judgement and long-term consequences often delay help-seeking until distress escalates into crisis. Normalising conversations around mental health within families, schools and health-care systems is not optional; it is a public health imperative.

The Ghaziabad case must not remain just a headline. Preventing similar tragedies requires coordinated action between schools, paediatricians, mental health professionals, and communities. Even modest, timely interventions can change developmental paths. While telepsychiatry and digital platforms have expanded reach, access remains unequal; extending these services to underserved families, alongside investment in training and interdisciplinary care, must be a priority.

Parents need guidance on early warning signs and healthy digital use. Schools should make mental wellbeing part of daily learning. Paediatricians must screen for emotional and behavioural issues, and community support networks strengthened. Policy must treat mental health as central to child development.

Equally important is a need to shift in what we value as outcomes. Childhood should foster wellbeing, resilience, and connection—not just competitiveness. Neglecting it now will carry far higher social and economic costs later.

of the total ammonia being imported, offering price predictability and greater insulation from global gas market volatility, currency risks and geopolitical pressures. In locations where grey ammonia costs are higher, green ammonia procurement increases its appeal for scale-up.

Propelling the momentum

India's approach is increasingly shaping the clean ammonia landscape worldwide, owing to its combination of low renewable energy costs, large-scale logistics, robust contract design and targeted incentives. As more countries seek reliable clean ammonia imports to decarbonise industry, power and transport, India's successful auction model is well placed to shape emerging global market structures and accelerate adoption at scale.

However, sustaining the momentum created by India's green ammonia auctions will require coordinated and sustained action from policymakers, project developers and financiers. Developers must focus on strong technical and financial due diligence, integrate hybrid renewable systems with storage, and adopt transparent monitoring frameworks to ensure long-term operational viability. Policymakers, in turn, need to provide stable and harmonised regulations on grid access, banking and incentives, while strengthening safety standards and aligning certification frameworks with evolving global norms.

Long-tenor, blended finance facilities, backed by extended offtake agreements and dedicated risk-mitigation instruments, can further enhance project bankability and crowd in private capital. Together, these measures can reinforce investor confidence, accelerate scale-up, and firmly position India not just as a participant but also as a global leader in clean ammonia markets.

The views expressed are personal

Rethinking tribal women’s inheritance rights

The question of women’s inheritance rights in tribal communities remains unresolved. Customary laws of most tribal communities deny absolute property rights to their women, and the Hindu Succession Act, 1956, which grants daughters inheritance rights in ancestral property, keeps tribal women out of its purview. Until recently, however, the Supreme Court had in some cases granted inheritance rights to tribal women who had ‘Hinduised’, i.e., adopted Hindu customs and traditions after abandoning their customary practices. This inconsistent approach – excluding tribal women from inheritance rights in some cases due to the acceptance of exclusion clauses under Hindu laws, while granting rights in others because of ‘Hinduisation’ – created uncertainty for tribal women whenever questions of inheritance arose.

Reaffirming an old principle
This came to an end when, on October 8, 2025, the Court delivered a verdict, upholding the core inheritance provisions of the Hindu Succession Act, 1956. A Bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and Prashant Kumar Mishra stated that the Act cannot be applied to Scheduled Tribes under any circumstances. While this observation was not new, it reaffirmed the law’s principle of providing special protection to indigenous communities under the legal system. The verdict was given in the case of *Nawang v. Bahadur*. The civil appeal challenged the order dated June 23, 2015, passed by the High Court of Himachal Pradesh at Shimla, pertaining to a particular property case. The High Court had said that tribal daughters who had been ‘Hinduised’ ought to have an opportunity to inherit property under the Hindu Succession Act. The Supreme Court overturned that order stating that only Parliament had the authority to extend the Act to tribal



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Now that the Supreme Court has ruled that the Hindu Succession Act does not apply to tribal communities, a separate law could be introduced to govern inheritance among indigenous populations

communities. The Court brought to light the fact that the High Court had overstepped its jurisdiction by directing legislative changes. It affirmed that tribal inheritance falls under the rubric of the customary practices of communities unless the Central government officially intervenes. The Supreme Court’s decision came just months after it recognised, in *Ram Charan v. Sukhram*, that excluding daughters from ancestral property violates their fundamental right to equality. It invites not only deep analysis, but also partially answers certain questions. Is ‘Hinduising’ a tribe the only way to secure inheritance rights for tribal women? Should Scheduled Tribes be granted inheritance rights solely on the basis of religion, disregarding their unique social and cultural characteristics? Can they not be given equal inheritance rights by expanding any other statute? Or, in the absence of consistent statutory and customary law guaranteeing tribal women inheritance rights, should tribal women continue to face discrimination under the pretext of upholding tradition?

Defining Hindu
On defining the term ‘Hindu’, the Supreme Court, in *Sastri Yagnapurushadji v. Muldas Brudardas Vaishya* (1966), said that “unlike other religions in the world, the Hindu religion does not claim any one prophet, it does not worship any one God, it does not subscribe to any one dogma, it does not believe in any one philosophic concept, it does not follow any one set of religious rites or performances, in fact, it does not appear to satisfy the narrow traditional features of any religion or creed. It may broadly be described as a way of life and nothing more”. A person can be a Hindu either by birth or by conversion. Conversion means a bonafide intention to follow a particular faith with an unequivocal conduct expressing sufficient evidence of conversion.

A converted person continues to be a member of the tribe unless his ancestors had converted long time ago and have stopped following tribal customs including the customary laws of inheritance and marriage, as are expected of the members of that tribe. This judgment of the Supreme Court raises a question. Was not the earlier practice of ‘Hinduisation’ of tribal people a negation of the constitutional guarantee to protect the unique identity of tribal people? The ruling affirms the constitutional validity of Section 2(2) of the Hindu Succession Act, which excludes Scheduled Tribes from the Act. This provision had previously been challenged on the grounds that it created invidious discrimination between women belonging to Scheduled Tribes and those outside the category. Earlier, the courts used to broaden the scope of Section 2(1) of the Hindu Succession Act to include Scheduled Tribes by holding that since they are not expressly excluded under the section, they would be included within the definition of ‘Hindu’ under Section 2(1) of the Act. This is not only contrary to Section 2(2), which states that notwithstanding anything to the contrary in Section 2(1), no provisions of the Act shall apply to notified Scheduled Tribes, but was also used to force tribal women to choose between their tribal identity and becoming followers of Hinduism.

An opportunity
Now that the Supreme Court has stated that the Act cannot be extended to tribal people irrespective of their religious allegiance, it would be wise to introduce a special enactment governing inheritance rights among the indigenous population. Codifying customary laws of succession in other States with significant tribal populations on the lines of Mizoram could provide a solution to ensure gender parity while preserving tribal identity.

Congress tightens grip, but tests lie ahead

The party cannot afford to be complacent even after winning the municipal polls

STATE OF PLAY

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The results of the 2026 Telangana municipal elections mark another milestone in the Congress’s steady political consolidation in Telangana. Before this, the party won the 2023 Assembly elections; secured eight seats in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, which was as many as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP); and won a majority of sarpanch positions in 2025. Together, these victories have strengthened the Congress’s organisational confidence and reinforced the public perception that the party is the new pole of stability in Telangana. The municipal results have also served as an internal stabiliser for the leadership. Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy appears to have firmly consolidated his position. Challengers and sceptics within the party seem to have resigned themselves to the reality that the Chief Minister is politically unshakeable, at least for the foreseeable future. It is not uncommon, however, for a ruling party to perform well in local body elections. The advantages of incumbency, visibility of welfare schemes, administrative access, a favourable bureaucracy, and the perceived ability of ruling party MLAs to get work done often weigh heavily on voter psychology. This phenomenon was evident in 2020 as well, when the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) swept over 95% of municipal bodies and captured the Zilla Parishad chairperson’s post in all the districts. However, a comparison between 2020 and 2026 also

highlights why the present Congress victory carries deeper political meaning. Unlike the BRS’s sweep of 2020, the Congress secured just over 70% of municipal wards this time. Yet, this outcome is significant precisely because Congress faced two strong Opposition parties. The BRS still commanded a sizeable presence with 37 MLAs (including 10 defectors), while the BJP entered the contest with eight MLAs and eight MPs. This stands in contrast to 2020, when the Congress was organisationally battered, reduced to just six MLAs, with 12 legislators defecting to the ruling BRS, and a mass migration of grassroots cadre. The BJP then had only one MLA, though it had four MPs. The Congress’s journey from that nadir to its current dominance shows the scale of its revival. The Congress has emerged as the single largest party this time. Securing 39.80% of the vote share, it finished 11.05% points ahead of the BRS. This gap is striking when viewed against the backdrop of the 2023 Assembly elections, where the difference between the two parties was just 2%. The Congress had already widened this lead in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, polling 40.1% while the BRS secured just 16.7%, with much of its vote share shifting to the BJP. The municipal polls reveal an interesting reversal. While the BRS recovered a signifi-

cant portion of its lost vote share, largely at the expense of the BJP, the Congress not only retained its base but also expanded it further. The BJP, which had polled nearly 35% in the Lok Sabha elections, slipped to a surprising 15.68%, which is a huge setback, especially in urban areas where it is considered strong. The scale of the Congress victory is evident in seat distribution too. Of the 2,996 wards across 123 urban local bodies, it secured 1,347, winning 99 out of the 123 municipalities and corporations that went to polls. The party emerged victorious in 68 of the 81 Assembly segments where municipal elections were held, despite major urban centres such as Hyderabad, Warangal, and Khammam being excluded from this round. Mr. Reddy himself set the campaign narrative in the final days, while adopting a decentralised approach that gave ministers and MLAs autonomy but with accountability. He also deftly diverted attention from sensitive urban governance issues towards broader political themes. Yet, the Congress cannot afford complacency. Nearly 38 municipalities delivered hung verdicts, underlining local dissatisfaction and factionalism. The BJP’s victory in Karimnagar Corporation and the BRS’s continued presence in several municipalities signal that urban Telangana remains politically competitive. Moreover, incumbency fatigue, governance delivery in urban areas, and internal party management will become bigger challenges as the Assembly elections approach. Transforming the present momentum into a second Assembly victory will depend on whether the Congress is able to address its weaknesses.

Why upper caste support matters for the BJP

Sustained majority-level support suggests that upper caste voters view the BJP as their primary political vehicle at the national level

DATA POINT

Sanjay Kumar
Vibha Attri

In recent weeks, there have been debates and protests in universities across India over the University Grants Commission (UGC) (Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions) Regulations, 2026, designed to promote fairness in higher education. The Supreme Court put the regulations on hold after concerns were raised that the key provisions were vague and prone to misuse. While the protests focused on educational policy, they also revealed political tensions, particularly among upper caste voters. This is a constituency that is historically significant to the BJP. Although the initial anger was directed at the UGC rules, it soon extended to criticism of the BJP. This was especially true of upper castes who may have been most affected if the regulations were implemented. The episode highlights the continuing electoral importance of upper castes for the party. Survey evidence from the National Election Study (NES) conducted by Lokniti-CSDS shows that upper caste Hindu voters have steadily consolidated behind the BJP and its allies over the past three decades (**Table 1**). While upper castes form a modest share of the electorate, their cohesion and concentration in key States enhance their influence. In the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, about 60% of upper caste voters backed the National Democratic Alliance, with 53% voting directly for the BJP. Around 20% backed the Congress-led alliance and 14% voted for the Congress. During the coalition era (1996-2004), upper caste voters leaned towards the BJP, though support had not yet reached majority levels for the party. The 2009 election marked a brief weakening. From 2014 onwards, consolidation

became clear: upper caste support for the BJP crossed 50% and has remained above that level. This sustained backing suggests that upper caste voters increasingly view the BJP as their main political choice at the national level. State-level data (2014-2024) show that this consolidation is geographically widespread. In Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, and Rajasthan, support for the BJP remained above 60% across three Lok Sabha elections. Delhi and Himachal Pradesh show similar stability (**Table 2**). In Telangana, where the BJP was historically weak, upper caste support rose sharply from 12% in 2014 to 53% in 2024. In West Bengal, support surged in 2019 before moderating in 2024, yet remained much higher than a decade earlier. In Assam and Odisha, upper caste voters have consistently favoured the BJP despite shifts in overall vote share. Together, this evidence indicates that upper caste support for the BJP is neither regionally confined nor episodic. It forms a durable pillar of the party’s coalition. Assembly elections provide a stricter test of alignment, as they are shaped more by regional leadership and local issues. If upper caste support were driven only by national mobilisation, it would likely be more volatile in these contests. The evidence instead shows continuity. In Uttar Pradesh, support rose from 71% in 2017 to 78% in 2022 (**Table 3**). In Madhya Pradesh, it increased sharply between 2018 and 2023. Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh remain competitive, yet upper caste support for the BJP is strong. Even in States dominated by regional parties, the BJP’s upper caste base has remained significant. Across elections, upper caste voters remain a stable and strategically important constituency for the BJP. This explain why policy debates seen as affecting upper caste interests can carry political implications that extend beyond the issue at hand.

Voting patterns

The data were sourced from the National Election Study (NES), 1996-2024 conducted by Lokniti-CSDS and the various State Assembly election studies conducted in different States by Lokniti-CSDS



All the figures are in percent

TABLE 1: Upper caste Hindu votes for the BJP and Congress: Lok Sabha elections 1996-2024

Year of election	BJP	BJP allies	NDA	Congress	Congress allies	UPA/ INDIA
1996	35	4	39	25	-	25
1998	36	14	50	25	3	28
1999	42	20	62	20	-	20
2004	36	17	53	22	7	29
2009	28	7	35	25	9	34
2014	47	9	56	13	3	16
2019	52	7	59	12	5	17
2024	53	7	60	14	6	20

TABLE 2: State-wise upper caste Hindu votes for the BJP and Congress: Lok Sabha elections 2014-2024

State	BJP 2014	BJP 2019	BJP 2024	Congress 2014	Congress 2019	Congress 2024
Bihar	77	76	53	1	2	2
UP	74	80	77	7	5	7
MP	64	75	72	24	24	20
Rajasthan	60	70	65	20	22	23
Chhattisgarh	46	72	74	17	16	17
Haryana	40	63	54	15	27	35
Delhi	62	75	71	10	12	14
Himachal	60	68	70	35	29	30
Jharkhand	77	63	58	7	5	14
Uttarakhand	64	80	67	30	16	22
Assam	65	55	44	23	13	20
West Bengal	21	57	43	4	3	4
Odisha	26	42	49	9	10	5
Karnataka	64	71	66	35	16	22
Telangana	12	38	53	15	25	29

Notes: Bihar: Include BJP allies (14% in LS 2014), (47% in LS 2019), (29% in LS 2024), Haryana: INLD-28% (2014 LS), Delhi: AAP (21% in LS 2014), (12% in LS 2019), (12% in LS 2024), Jharkhand: JVM (10% in LS 2014), in 2019 3% of AJSU included in BJP, West Bengal: In LS 2014 (AITC-40%, LF-29%), in LS 2019 (AITC-31%, LF-9%), in LS 2024 (AITC-43%, LF-7%)

Sanjay Kumar is a Professor and political analyst. Vibha Attri is a researcher working with Lokniti-CSDS. Views expressed by the authors are personal, do not reflect views of their institution.

TABLE 3: Upper caste Hindu vote for the BJP and Congress and major regional parties. Last two State Assembly elections in different States:

State	Year of election	BJP/ NDA	Congress/ INDIA bloc/ MGB
Bihar	2020	54	16
	2025	67	9
UP	2017	71	2
	2022	78	1
MP	2018	57	32
	2023	74	21
Rajasthan	2018	50	35
	2023	61	32
Chhattisgarh	2018	50	43
	2023	54	39
Haryana	2014	37	18
	2024	42	39
Delhi	2020	54	3
	2025	62	4
Himachal	2017	51	38
	2022	49	38
Jharkhand	2019	42	25
	2024	66	20
Uttarakhand	2017	56	27
	2022	60	26
Assam	2016	71	20
	2021	68	21
West Bengal	2016	13	13
	2021	45	2
Karnataka	2018	42	32
	2023	60	22
Telangana	2018	10	33
	2023	20	39

Notes: Haryana 2014: INLD (26), Delhi 2020: AAP (41), Delhi 2025: AAP (30), West Bengal 2016: AITC (43), West Bengal 2021: AITC (40), West Bengal 2021: AITC (40), Karnataka 2018: JD(S) (18), Karnataka 2023: JD(S) (14), Telangana 2018: TRS/BRS (44), Telangana 2023: TRS/BRS (36)

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO FEBRUARY 24, 1976

Photo-setting for books: Plant in Bangalore

Bangalore, Feb. 25: The Macmillan group of companies, the internationally known publishers, have selected Bangalore for locating their modern type-setting plant because of its climate, which is suited to men and woman as also the computers in the plant, as Mr. Harold Macmillan put it. The former British Prime Minister and President of the Macmillan group of companies inaugurated the plant here this afternoon. The Rs. 40-lakh-plant has been set up for photo-setting pages of texts composed for printing. The film negatives will be composed with the aid of computerised monokeyboards and film-setters. However the printing of the books would be done in the United Kingdom and Australia with the use of the films exported from Bangalore. The investment in the project will be doubled next year. After the inauguration of the most modern type-setting project, Mr. Macmillan said his company had begun a “new phase of association between the U.K. and India which would open up a new field of exports for the latter.” He envisaged that the value of exports of films from the plant would go up to Rs. one crore a year by 1978. Production would begin in a month or two. He recalled that the company opened its branch in India over 100 years ago. To-day its operations in India were being carried on by an Indian company called the Macmillan Company of India Limited. **A HUNDRED YEARS AGO** FEBRUARY 24, 1926 **Emigrants from Fiji** A representative of “The Hindu” interviewed the emigrants last night and was able to gather the following particulars concerning the present condition of the Indian labourers in Fiji, the wages obtaining there and the facilities afforded to them for settlement and comfortable living. Their general appearance, to begin with, betokened extreme poverty, great suffering and hardship. Enquired about the general conditions in Fiji they all represented, without one single exception, that Fiji was no doubt a good and comparatively healthy place to settle down but they would never advise their brethren in India to leave their homes.

INBRIEF



Indian nationals advised to leave Iran amid rising tension

India on Monday advised all its nationals residing in Iran to leave the country by all available means of transport in view of the evolving security situation in the country. The Indian Embassy in Iran issued a fresh advisory to Indian nationals amid renewed protests in Tehran, and increasing fears of U.S. military strikes on the Gulf nation. According to official estimates, in January, a little over 10,000 Indians, including students, were living in Iran. “In view of the evolving situation in Iran, Indian nationals who are currently in Iran (students, pilgrims, business persons and tourists) are advised to leave Iran by available means of transport, including commercial flights,” the Embassy said.

RSS-backed trade union to launch nationwide protest

Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh (BMS), the RSS-backed trade union, has decided to launch protests in every district on February 25 against the labour policies of the Union and State governments. The BMS demanded the Centre to urgently convene the tripartite body Indian Labour Conference to discuss workers’ issues, including the implementation of the four Labour Codes. Talking to reporters in Delhi on Monday, BMS leaders said the Centre has promised that it will make amendments to the Code on Industrial Relations and the Code on Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions in the second leg of the Budget Session beginning on March 9.

‘Self-reliance key to India’s ambition of becoming maritime superpower’

India has to create a maritime ecosystem to take leadership in the sector, says Union Minister for Ports, Shipping and Waterways; India will be among top five ship-building nations by 2047, he says

INTERVIEW
Sarbananda Sonowal

Shankari Nivethitha. B
THOOTHUKUDI

India cannot keep depending on foreign shipping lines for trade and has to create a maritime ecosystem to take leadership in the sector, says Sarbananda Sonowal, Union Minister for Ports, Shipping, and Waterways. The Minister spoke about India’s push towards green shipping fuels, shipbuilding expansion, and progress of the Sagarmala projects. Edited excerpts:



How does the Centre plan to scale green hydrogen and e-methanol hubs to ensure India leads as the primary bunker destination for global green shipping corridors by 2030?

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched the National Hydrogen Mis-

sion, it was to promote green transport to achieve a blue economy. As follow-up action, we are developing infrastructure, so that in the near future, hydrogen, ammonia, and all our renewable energy can be promoted. Our target is to combat climate change.

Given the nation’s goal to reach the top five countries in the ship-building sector, what are the specific execution milestones up ahead?

India cannot depend on foreign ships all the time. We want to grow on our own, that is why, in the principle of “Atmanirbhar Bharat”, we want to create the ecosystem within India, so we

can take leadership in this sector. For this, the Prime Minister has indicated two paths: Maritime India Vision 2030 and Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047.

As part of this, by 2030, we will be one of the top 10 ship-building nations in the world, and by 2047, we will be among the top five.

The Sagarmala programme has been witnessing a reduction in funds. Will that affect any ongoing projects in Tamil Nadu?

No, we are committed to whatever projects we have already accepted, we have already approved and committed. The project’s work will definitely be done within the timeline.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The instant messaging platform WhatsApp maintained in the Supreme Court on Monday that it was not “quite right” to say the online entity was sharing data with other Meta platforms. Appearing before a three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, senior advocate Kapil Sibal, for WhatsApp and its parent company, Meta, said its technology was very clear and put a premium on privacy. “There is no question of violating the law,” Mr. Sibal submitted.

He said the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, comprehensively addressed the privacy concerns raised in the Supreme Court.

The court was hearing petitions filed by Meta and WhatsApp against a National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) decision to uphold a ₹213.14-crore penalty imposed by the Competition Commission of India (CCI).

The CCI had found WhatsApp’s “take-it-or-leave-it” approach in its

Privacy message

WhatsApp submits its view before SC on user consent and sharing of data with Meta

WhatsApp and Meta challenge NCLAT order upholding ₹213.14-crore penalty imposed by CCI

Case arises from CCI findings on WhatsApp’s 2021 privacy policy

WhatsApp denies improper sharing, cites encryption and DPDP Act

KEY ALLEGATION

CCI found WhatsApp’s 2021 privacy policy a ‘take-it-or-leave-it’ practice

Regulator said users were forced to share data with Meta to keep using the app

Tribunal stressed user choice and consent for non-essential data use

DEFENDING STATEMENTS

Company says it will follow NCLAT directions by March 16, 2026

CCI argued the matter also involves competition law and consumer protection

2021 privacy policy an abuse of its market dominance. It found the prior consent sought from users to share their data with Meta “manufactured”. It had concluded that users were forced to share data for continued access to WhatsApp messaging services.

In an appeal last year, the NCLAT concluded that the “core principle is to remove exploitation by restoring user choice”.

“The users can be given choice if users retain the right to decide what data is collected from them, for which purposes, and for how long. We had also stat-



ed in our findings that any non-essential collection or cross-use (like advertising etc.) can occur only with the concerned user’s express and revocable consent,” the NCLAT had observed.

On Monday, WhatsApp said it would fully comply with the NCLAT directions relating to user consent for sharing data with Meta under its controversial 2021 privacy policy by March 16, 2026. The tribunal had, however, found the CCI’s five-year ban on sharing data for advertisement purposes “redundant”, considering that the user

Bihar bans meat, fish sales near schools and religious places

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

The sale of meat and fish near religious places, educational institutions or crowded locations has been banned in Bihar to stop “violent tendencies” in children, Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Kumar Sinha has said while referring to a letter sent to municipal commissioners on meat shops operating in the open in urban areas.

“This is a new initiative of the new government. We held a meeting and we took seriously the issues raised... From a health perspective, for social interaction, and to prevent violent tendencies among children, we will ban the sale of meat and fish near educational and religious institutions, and in crowded open spaces,” he said on Sunday.

Mr. Sinha, also the Urban Development and Housing Department Minister, was referring to a letter sent by the department’s Principal Secretary, Vinay Kumar.

The Minister, however, clarified that the State government had no objection to food preferences of people, but said that strict measures had been taken to ensure that “social interaction and the spirit of



Vijay Kumar Sinha

purity are not violated”. He said that “no one’s sentiments should be hurt, and the environment must not be polluted”.

Violation of provisions Mr. Kumar had written to all municipal commissioners stating that illegal meat and fish shops were operating under various municipal bodies in violation of the provisions of Section 345 of the Bihar Municipal Act, 2007. However, in the letter, he did not mention about “violent tendencies” in children caused by meat shops.

“Such shops are either operating without licences or the conditions of the licences have not been ensured. Furthermore, meat is being sold in the open and in unsanitary conditions, and dead animals are being displayed,” the letter said.

Pray for peace to return in Manipur, says Boong director after BAFTA win

Press Trust of India
LONDON

Filmmaker Lakshmi Priya Devi, whose debut feature *Boong* won a BAFTA award at a glittering ceremony in London on Sunday, used the moment on stage to pray for peace in her home State of Manipur.

“The walk up till here felt like the last few steps to reach the summit of a mountain we never knew we were climbing in the first place. I just want to use this opportunity to say that we pray for peace to return in Manipur,” Ms. Devi said in her acceptance speech.

Boong, a Manipuri film starring Gugun Kipgen and Bala Hijam, won the award in the Best Children’s and Family Film category.

“We pray that all the internally displaced children, including the child



Winning team: Director Lakshmi Priya Devi with producers Alan McAlex, left, Farhan Akhtar, and Ritesh Sidhwani in London. AP

actors in the film, regain their joy, their innocence, and their dreams once again. We pray that no conflict is ever formidable enough to destroy the one superpower that all of us have as human beings, that is forgiveness,” she added.

In a backstage interaction with presspersons, she said the movie was inspired by the folk tales of her grandmother.

Producer Farhan Akhtar said backing the film set in a region of India from which we rarely get to watch films “just felt right”.

‘Moment of joy’ Congratulatory messages poured in from Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Manipur Chief Minister Y. Khemchand Singh, and many in the industry.

“Congratulations to all those associated with this film. This is indeed a moment of immense joy, especially for Manipur. It also highlights the immense creative talent in our country,” Mr. Modi said in a post on X.

Mr. Singh said the win was a moment of immense pride not only for Manipur but for the entire nation.

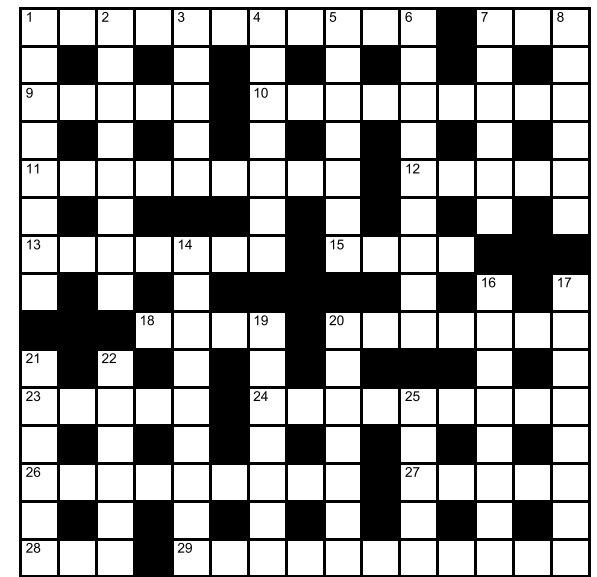
LIST OF WINNERS
» WORLD PAGE

THE CROSSWORD+ 14725

(set by Arden)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- Across
- Fantastic idea, note India gets more coverage - it's a reminder (4-7)
 - Stole a launch, almost (3)
 - Old jail they say is best (5)
 - Regularly impair by blocking new beneficiary (9)
 - Motherland's hell-fire (9)

- Like to check however, for fungus (5)
 - Brief pull out (7)
 - Keep here evenly - you'll need it for fencing (4)
 - Boring review of a poet (4)
 - Playing team - regret about it being not professional (7)
 - Groom very softly bites lip (5)
 - Respite on assignment (9)
 - "Drink from birth" - recollected a cheat (9)
 - Forget talk of rejecting some coffee (5)
 - Wool supplier - see how one ends up (3)
 - They look for another aspect with Harry (6,5)
- Down
- Bluebeard - born and raised in the city (8)
 - Killed uprising- China will destroy (8)
 - Holding formal talks in the island nation (5)
 - Red planet swallows eleven tons (7)
 - Infuriate a smoker (7)
 - Perhaps same hype about millions suffering from breathlessness (9)
 - Extra police for regulation by local authorities (6)
 - Cause trustee to reject the odd ones - very clever (6)
 - After a harvest, grain storage came up in the outskirts of Athens (9)
 - Go-between randomly to admire (8)
 - Greenhouse or cross over energy? (8)
 - Bitter about a cap - part of habit (7)
 - Annual call by clearing banks - crazy to lose interest (7)
 - Father in pain, is brave (6)
 - Delusion over border, time to support (6)
 - Maybe helps to carry (5)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Abhisheka Kandan

There is a Murugan temple in Sri Lanka, which is connected with a Tamil princess, said Desa Mangayarkkarasi in a discourse. Due to a curse, this princess had a digestive disorder, and the face of a horse. She visited Tiruchendur hoping for a cure. In Tiruchendur, Murugan faces the sea. The place which He faces is called Vadana Aramba Thurai. The princess bathed here, and a voice was heard. The voice instructed her to go to Keerimalai in Sri Lanka. The voice said there was a swayambhu Murugan in Keerimalai, and asked her to worship this Murugan for relief from her curse. Since the means of acquiring a human face was suggested here, this place in Tiruchendur is called Vadana Aramba Thurai. Vadana means face; aramba means beginning. Thurai means bathing ghat.

The princess went to Keerimalai, where sage Nakula, also known as Keeri muni, was doing penance. He had been cursed with the face of a mongoose, and this curse had vanished when he had worshipped Lord Siva in this place. Sage Nakula guided the princess to the swayambhu Murugan. This place in Lanka is called Mavittapuram, and Murugan here is known as Maavai Kandan. He is also called Abhisheka Kandan. Although abhishekas for deities are common in temples, this place in Lanka is unique because the deity here has the prefix abhisheka before His name.

INBRIEF



SECL eyeing 7.5 MT of coking coal in Chhattisgarh, M.P.

South Eastern Coalfields Ltd. (SECL) would be tapping into coking coal and has already assessed potential for 7.5 million tonnes (MT) across varied regions in Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh, B.N. Jha, Area General Manager of Baikunthpur (Chhattisgarh) said on Monday. “We have already affirmed the potential for coking coal in the Kewai block (Madhya Pradesh),” he stated, adding, “Further, in the Baikunthpur [Chhattisgarh] area itself, we have affirmed the potential in Labji Pusla mine and Katkona mine.”

Morepen Labs shares surge on bagging ₹825 crore deal

Morepen Laboratories shares surged more than 15% on Monday after the drugmaker said it had secured a multi-year contract development and manufacturing organisation (CDMO) mandate valued around ₹825 crore (\$91 million) from a leading global pharma major. Supplies, under the mandate, are expected to commence within next 4-5 months, with execution scheduled through Q1 of the following financial year. The shares closed ₹45.37 each on the BSE.

India amends tax treaty with France, cuts dividend tax

India has revised its three-decade-old tax treaty with France, which will help major French firms save millions of dollars in dividend levies, while it also broadens New Delhi’s powers to tax certain transactions, the finance ministry said. French firms holding at least 10% in an Indian entity will now pay a 5% tax on dividends, down from 10% earlier. For minority French shareholdings of under 10% in Indian companies, however, dividend tax will rise from 10% to 15%. REUTERS

‘SEBI will probe egregious behaviour in employees’

Ashokamithran T. MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) will “get to the bottom of it” if any evidence of egregious behaviour is found in employees, Chairperson Tuhin Kanta Pandey said here on Monday.

It is important to take action if evidence of “egregious behaviour” arises, to avoid dissuading those who work with integrity, Mr. Pandey said, responding to questions on the suspension of General Manager Achal Singh over alleged ‘integrity issues’.

“It’s important that if there’s any such case, we’ll get to the bottom of it. But we do have [the] whole system in place to see that due opportunity is given, natural justice is given. Nevertheless, [in] the initial stage, the evidence was egregious enough for us to act,” Mr. Pandey said at a media briefing.

On the ease of doing business front, Mr. Pandey, during his speech at an event, said that a comprehensive review of the SEBI (Portfolio Manager) regulations was underway and that the regulator was targeting to release a consultation paper proposing the changes by June.

He further said that SEBI was looking into representations from stock brokers regarding the Reserve Bank of India’s (RBI) new norm mandating a 100% collateral on credit to stock brokers among others.

IDFC First staff plotted with outsiders in ₹590 cr. fraud’

Isolated case involved one branch and a Haryana government entity, recovery process initiated says CEO: bank well-capitalised to absorb shock, but magnitude of the issue is ‘disturbing’

Lalatendu Mishra MUMBAI

IDFC First Bank employees had perpetrated a ₹590 crore bank fraud through a ‘traditional method’ by colluding with external parties using forged physical cheque transactions, the private sector bank’s MD and CEO V. Vaidyanathan said on Monday, a day after the bank reported the matter to the stock exchanges.

However, he said this was a “specific, isolated case involving one branch in Chandigarh and one client group, a Haryana Government entity, and not system-wide”. He said no senior management staff of the bank was involved in the fraud and that the recovery process had been initiated. Four bank staff had been suspended.

“It’s a case of employee fraud and external parties are involved. The bank has all the systems in place, but in this case it’s not an electronic transfer and it’s not a digital fraud. It’s an older, traditional kind of

In the red

IDFC First Bank stock tanked 16% a day after the ₹590 cr. fraud involving the bank’s staff came to light

■ Not digital fraud, but ‘traditional kind’ in connivance with employees, says MD

■ Discrepancy comprises ₹490 cr. identified after reconciliation, ₹100 cr. self-identified via internal checks

■ Lender to make provisions during this quarter, ‘will still be profitable’



fraud in connivance with employees. It is a case of collusion,” Mr. Vaidyanathan told analysts over an investor conference call.

He said the bank had initiated necessary steps including police complaint to deal with the matter, first time in its 10-year history. It has also appointed KPMG as independent forensic auditor to detect the modus operandi.

The report is expected in four to five weeks, he said. Assuring investors and customers that a proper investigation would be conducted, Mr. Vaidyanathan said the bank was well capitalised to “bear

the shock”. “The bank is well capitalised and profitability is in positive territory. As far as the bank is concerned, it is now financially very strong but the magnitude of the issue has disturbed us. We will take provisions for this during this quarter. Despite this hit, we will still be profitable,” he emphasised.

The bank has been making a quarterly profit of about ₹500 crore. He said the discrepancy of ₹590 crore comprised ₹490 crore that was identified after reconciliation and ₹100 crore of ‘self identified’ one through internal checks, he said, declining

Bharti to invest \$2.2 bn to expand digital lending

Reuters

Bharti Airtel on Monday said it will invest ₹200 billion (\$2.2billion) in its financial arm over the next few years, as the telco steps up its push into digi-

tal lending.

The capital will be infused into its subsidiary, Airtel Money, which received a non-banking financial company (NBFC) licence from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Fe-

bruary 13.

Bharti’s expansion comes as competition intensifies in India’s non-bank lending sector, where conglomerates such as Jio Financial Services and established players like Bajaj

Finance are scaling up retail credit operations.

The move strengthens Airtel’s financial services business as it diversifies beyond telecom into areas such as data centres, cloud and enterprise services.

MARKETS

MARKET WATCH

	MONDAY	% CHANGE
Sensex	83,295	0.58
US Dollar	90.89	0.05
Gold	1,62,800	2.06
Brent oil	71.88	

NIFTY 50

	PRICE	CHANGE
Adani Enter	2191.00	30.20
Adani Ports	1555.80	44.30
Apollo Hosp.	7693.00	77.50
Asian Paints	2429.70	1.60
Axis Bank	1386.70	18.40
Bajaj Auto	9905.50	98.50
Bajaj Finserv	2051.60	6.90
Bajaj Finance	1031.00	0.80
Bharat Elec.	439.75	-1.40
Bharti Airtel	1997.30	19.90
Cipla	1326.50	-14.60
Coal India	426.00	-2.45
Dr Reddys Lab	1307.40	27.00
Eicher Motors	8038.50	102.00
Eternal Ltd.	268.00	-1.45
Grasim Ind.	2873.40	40.60
HCL Tech	1426.20	-10.30
HDFC Bank	923.60	11.75
HDFC Life	742.45	13.80
Hindalco	916.20	-19.50
Hind Unilever	2345.40	30.90
ICI Bank	1399.40	4.90
IntGlobeAvi.	4862.20	7.60
Infosys	1327.50	-25.70
ITC	325.40	-1.60

Jio Financial Service Ltd.	257.80	-0.80
JSW Steel	1240.50	4.70
Kotak Bank	430.70	9.35
Kwality Walls	26.95	-0.78
L&T	4418.10	37.50
M&M	3447.10	34.30
Maruti Suzuki	15072.00	95.00
Max Healthcare	1083.60	-4.30
NestleIndia	1315.10	21.30
NTPC	375.45	2.50
ONGC	275.65	-3.00
PowerGrid Corp	303.35	4.40
Reliance Ind.	1428.00	8.60
SBI Life	2109.60	29.60
State Bank	1227.80	11.70
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1064.70	5.40
Sun Pharma	1732.30	7.90
TataConsumerProduct	1171.80	15.60
Tata Steel	208.14	-0.22
TCS	2676.30	-9.90
Tech Mahindra	1440.90	-16.00
Titan	4272.70	36.30
Tata Motors PV	379.95	1.95
Trent Ltd.	4054.90	-36.10
UltraTech Cement	12976.00	210.00
Wipro	205.89	-3.97

RODTEP rates cut

The Directorate General of Foreign Trade has amended the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products Scheme so that the rate applicable for all products shall be limited to 50% of existing rates and, where applicable, 50% of the notified value caps, with immediate effect.

What happens to India’s Russian oil imports, \$500-bn U.S. import goal?

NEWS ANALYSIS

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan NEW DELHI



Pressure tactics: The value of India’s Russian oil imports fell to a 38-month low in December 2025. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

The Indian trade delegation’s last-minute postponement of trip to Washington to finalise an Interim Agreement with the U.S., and the U.S. Supreme Court’s order on tariffs both have implications for India’s imports from Russia as well as the U.S.

The Indian delegation was to be in the U.S. on February 23-25 to finalise the Interim Agreement, which Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said could be implemented between mid-March and early April. However, sources in the Commerce Ministry on February 22 said that the meeting will be rescheduled “at a mutually convenient date”.

“The two sides are of the view that the proposed visit of the Indian chief negotiator and the team be scheduled after each side has had the time to evaluate the latest developments and its implications,” the official said.

Mr. Goyal had earlier said India would be able to remove or lower tariffs for American imports only after a deal is signed. The U.S., on the other hand, could so far modify tariffs through executive orders.

No Russian oil threats

Trade and legal experts, said U.S. SC order meant President Trump no longer had any law enabling him to levy tariffs on India if it continues buying Russian oil in large quantities.

Without the tariff threat, India can once again reduce its purchase of the relatively expensive

American oil and sour Venezuelan oil.

“With reciprocal tariffs gone, the U.S. now does not have any law under which it can penalise India for buying Russian oil,” Ajay Srivastava, founder of the Global Trade Research Initiative and former Director General of Foreign Trade said. “Even if we were to continue our oil imports from the U.S., which have nearly doubled in the last few months, we should refrain from buying oil from Venezuela.”

It is important to note Mr. Trump had, on February 6 itself, removed the tariffs linked to India’s import of Russian oil. As per Ramesh K. Vaidyanathan, managing partner at law firm BTG Advaya, tariffs could theoretically return, but they would need the backing of U.S. Congress.

Multiple mechanisms

“There are multiple legal mechanisms under which he can do this, but I think what is coming to the fore is that he cannot do these through executive orders and will have to do it under legislative backing for the purpose for which they are designed.” In other words, if Mr. Trump can convince the U.S. Congress that ta-

riffs linked to Russian oil imports are necessary, then they could return.

An analysis by *The Hindu* found the value of India’s crude oil imports from Russia fell to a 38-month low in December 2025 with Russia’s share falling to less than a quarter from 34% a month ago. However, oil imports from the U.S. rose almost 31% over December 2024.

The analysis showed India imported oil from the U.S. at an average price of \$506.7 per tonne in December 2025 or almost 8% higher than the average price of Russian oil imported that month.

Uncertainty over deal

“India should follow a wait-and-watch approach and should see how other countries that have signed deals with the U.S. are reacting,” said Pankaj Chadha, chairman of exporter body EEPIC India.

Mr. Srivastava says the decision to postpone the Indian team’s visit to Washington could simply be an “administrative delay”.

“There is a possibility that this delay in the Indian team’s visit to the U.S. could have been at the request of the U.S. since their officials would be under

fire trying to figure out the way forward.”

Impact on imports

A delayed Interim Agreement will also push back the date from which India will have to reduce tariffs for imports from the U.S. This can have a dual effect.

On the one hand, local manufacturers can breathe a bit easier since they will not have to compete with duty-free U.S. imports.

On the other several items India imports will continue to face import tariffs, thereby making them more expensive than they would have been had the deal gone through.

Mr. Goyal had previously told *The Hindu* there were several items such as oil, LPG, LNG, aircraft and parts, parts for data centres and quantum computing that India needs but does not manufacture, and so would need to import.

India’s imports of electronic parts grew 117% year-on-year to about \$2.1 billion in April-December 2025. Similarly, the import of telecom instruments rose 25% and organic chemicals by almost 34%.

A joint statement said India intends to import \$500 billion worth of energy products, aircraft and aircraft parts, precious metals, technology products, and coking coal from the U.S. over the next 5 years.

The European Union (EU) also said the U.S. must provide more clarity before EU Parliament can ratify the U.S.-EU deal.

Meanwhile, Japanese officials said they won’t immediately be revisiting the deal adding, the crux of Japan’s deal with U.S. was on lowering auto-related tariffs, which stay unaffected by the U.S. SC decision.

**TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED**
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E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE
The APTRANSCO invites bids online for Spec No.PMM31-e-17/2026.
Nature of Work: Procurement for Supply of various C&R Panels with BCUs required for BESS I&II, Augmentation of PTRs, RMI 2024-25 & O&M 2025-26
Works Date & Time of availability of Tenders: **23.02.2026 at 05:00 PM.**
Web: <https://tender.apeprocurement.gov.in>
RO. No : GMCC/APTRANSCO/55/26 Sd/- Chief Engineer/Transmission



RAJASTHAN AGRICULTURAL RESEARCH INSTITUTE
(S.K.N. AGRICULTURE UNIVERSITY, JOBNER)
DURGAPURA, JAIPUR
NOTICE INVITING BIDS (NIB No:- SKN2526A0437) Date: 17.02.2026
Unique Bid Number (UBN): SKN2526WLOB00472
Sealed E-Bids are invited on behalf of Rajasthan Agricultural Research Institute, Durgapura, Jaipur (Rajasthan) for the procurement of E-Tender for Construction of Plant Tissue Culture Lab and Protected Structures with Supply, Installation and Commissioning of Laboratory Equipment's on Turnkey Basis upto 09.03.2026, 02:00 PM.

S. No.	Name of Article	Specifications	Qty	Estimated Price (Rupees)	Price of Bidding Document (Rupees)	RISL Fee (Rs.)	Amount of Bid Security (Rupees)
1	E-Tender for Construction of Plant Tissue Culture Lab and Protected Structures with Supply, Installation and Commissioning of Laboratory Equipment's on Turnkey Basis		1500.00 Lakh (15 Cr.)	10000/-	2500/-	Rs. 30,00,000/-	

Details may be seen in the Bidding Document at our office or on the website of the State Public Procurement Portal <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>, <https://sppc.rajasthan.gov.in> or our website www.sknau.ac.in and may be downloaded from there or obtained from our office on payment of its Banker Cheque/demand draft.
Raj.Samwad/C/2514007 Director

**Karnataka Soaps & Detergents Limited**
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
Sandal City: P.B. No. 5531, Bengaluru-Pune Highway, Bengaluru - 560 055.
Ph: 080-22164879, 22164886, Website: www.mysoresandal.org e-mail: ksdl.dgmmtls@gmail.com
Date: 23.02.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Tenders are invited by **KS&DL** in two cover system through Karnataka Public Procurement Portal (Website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in/>) with respect to supply of following Goods/Services/Works.

Sl. No.	Tender Number	Tender Name	Tender Quantity	Published date	Last Date of Submission
1	KSDL/2025-26/IND0979	Procurement of Mysore Carbolic Soap 150g Cartons	1765833 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
2	KSDL/2025-26/IND0980	Procurement of Mysore Carbolic Soap-150g Corrugated Boxes	16331 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
3	KSDL/2025-26/IND0981	Procurement of Herbal Care Soap 100g Cartons	942500 Nos	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
4	KSDL/2025-26/IND0982	Procurement of Herbal Care 100g Corrugated Boxes	6533 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
5	KSDL/2025-26/IND0983	Procurement of Shrink Sleeves for Hand Wash Bottle top cover	1268717 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
6	KSDL/2025-26/IND0984	Procurement of Cellophane Paper Wrapper Reams	227500 Ream	21-02-2026	26-03-2026
7	KSDL/2025-26/IND0985	Procurement of Gift Pack Cartons	118083 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
8	KSDL/2025-26/IND0986	Procurement of Gift Pack Plastic Container	118083 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
9	KSDL/2025-26/IND0987	Procurement of Gift Pack Corrugated Boxes	9799 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
10	KSDL/2025-26/IND0988	Procurement of Ethylene Vinyl Acetate (EVA) based hot melt adhesive	8667 Kgs	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
11	KSDL/2025-26/IND0989	Procurement of Mysore Sandal Kleenol 5ltr PET bottle / Can with inner lid and cap	81656 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
12	KSDL/2025-26/IND0990	Procurement of Mysore Sandal Kleenol 5 ltr. Corrugated Boxes with Partition and Top plate	16331 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
13	KSDL/2025-26/IND0991	Procurement of Mysore Sandal Kleenol 5 ltr. Sticker (Front & Back)	82469 Nos.	21-02-2026	04-03-2026
14	KSDL/2025-26/IND0992	Procurement of Mysore Sandal Gold (125g x 3 Nos.) Cartons	261083 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
15	KSDL/2025-26/IND0993	Procurement of Mysore Sandal Gold (125gX3 Nos.) Corrugated Boxes	8710 Nos.	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
16	KSDL/2025-26/IND1002	Procurement of Tetramethyl perhydronaptho furan Ambroxan	900 Kgs	21-02-2026	26-03-2026
17	KSDL/2025-26/IND1003	Procurement of Coumarin crystals	29500 Kgs	21-02-2026	26-03-2026
18	KSDL/2025-26/IND1004	Procurement of Clove Leaf Oil	45900 Kgs	21-02-2026	26-03-2026
19	KSDL/2025-26/IND1005	Procurement of Habanolide/Globalide	8300 Kgs	21-02-2026	26-03-2026
20	KSDL/2025-26/IND1006	Procurement of Citronellol	25700 Kgs	21-02-2026	26-03-2026
21	KSDL/2025-26/IND1007	Procurement of Geranium oil	8500 Kgs	21-02-2026	26-03-2026
22	KSDL/2025-26/IND1010	Procurement of Kathon CG	7700 Kgs	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
23	KSDL/2025-26/IND1011	Procurement of Almond oil	13600 Kgs	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
24	KSDL/2025-26/IND1012	Procurement of Cocamidopropyl Betaine (CAPB)	40 MT	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
25	KSDL/2025-26/IND1013	Procurement of Cos Oil Yellow 4G (D & C YELLOW No. 11) CI No. 47000	7000 Kgs	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
26	KSDL/2025-26/IND1014	Procurement of Emulsifier	34000 Kgs	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
27	KSDL/2025-26/IND1015	Procurement of Carbopol Aqua SF-1	2100 Kgs	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
28	KSDL/2025-26/IND1016	Procurement of Caustic Soda Lye (on 100 percent basis)	70 MT	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
29	KSDL/2025-26/IND1017	Procurement of Amisoft	3600 Kgs	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
30	KSDL/2025-26/IND1018	Procurement of Tetra sodium salt of etidronic acid/Aqua acid - 1054 CG	6500 Kgs	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
31	KSDL/2025-26/IND1019	Procurement of LIQUID PARAFFIN LIGHT	11000 Kgs	21-02-2026	09-03-2026
32	KSDL/2025-26/IND1020	Procurement of EDTA Liquid	110 MT	21-02-2026	09-03-2026

For any further queries/clarifications please contact the undersigned.
Sd/- Asst. General Manager (Materials)

CM
YK

BAG OF TRICKS

Motie’s wrist spin has been beneficial for us, says Hope



EMMANUAL YOGINI

Motie has been one of our best bowlers, and it is great to see him come back having used that time (away from the game) wisely. He has clearly worked on his skills and added something extra with his wrist spin, which has been very beneficial for us — West Indies captain Shai Hope on left-arm spinner Gudakesh Motie.

BANG BANG

West Indies-Zimbabwe match sees 31 maximums, a T20 WC record



EMMANUAL YOGINI

The combined tally of 31 sixes in the Super Eight clash between West Indies (19 maximums) and Zimbabwe (12) in Mumbai on Monday is the highest in a T20 World Cup game. The previous record was the 30 maximums smacked in the Ireland-Netherlands game from the 2014 showpiece.

INVALUABLE ADVICE

Learnt slower balls from Bravo during my time at CSK: Ngidi



FILE PHOTO: VIJAY SONEJI

South Africa pacer Lungi Ngidi revealed that he learnt the art of bowling slower deliveries from Dwayne Bravo during his time at Chennai Super Kings in 2018. “I was with Bravo... the entire IPL, that is all I worked on. I was not playing (much), so I got time to practice it. When I got back to South Africa, I tried to perfect that ball”.

TALISMAN

It is good that teams are preparing for Tariq, says Pakistan’s Farhan



AFP

If you give 20-24 runs in a T20 match, that is a big deal. At times, Usman has gone for less than that. It is good that teams are preparing for him. They are worried about him and his bowling action. I think it is good for Pakistan’s confidence — Pakistan’s Sahibzada Farhan on spinner Usman Tariq.

Hetmyer, Powell lead Caribbean carnival at the Wankhede

The two batters smash 122 off just 52 balls for the third wicket as the West Indies amasses 254 for six, the second-highest total in the history of the tournament; left-arm spin twins Motie and Hosein combine to shoot out Zimbabwe for 147

T20 WORLD CUP

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Shimron Hetmyer was searing. Rovman Powell was remorseless. And when the all-rounders muscled in, West Indies turned the Super Eight Group 1 clash into a carnival of Caribbean carnage, clubbing Zimbabwe into submission at the Wankhede Stadium on a manic Monday night.

Powered by a 122-run partnership off just 52 balls between Hetmyer (85, 34b, 7x4, 7x6) and Powell (59, 35b, 4x4, 4x6), West Indies racked up a gargantuan 254 for six — the second-highest total in Men’s T20 World Cup history. Zimbabwe, burdened by the asking rate and the occasion, wilted in reply and was bundled out for 147 in 17.4 overs. The two-time champion won by 107 runs even as Brad Evans waged a lone battle with a 21-ball 43.

When Sikandar Raza opted to chase, he would have hoped the in-form Blessing Muzarabani and the returning Richard Ngarava would exploit the evening sea breeze. And there was an early opening. Had Tashinga Musekwa held on to a chance at deep square-leg in the fourth over off Muzarabani, Hetmyer’s evening would have been cut short.



Making a statement: Hetmyer and Powell carted the Zimbabwean bowlers to all parts of the ground. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Instead, the left-hander unleashed mayhem.

Hetmyer transformed the middle overs into a highlight reel of leg-side brutality, his 108-metre six off Raza — which clattered into the North Stand’s top tier railing — the standout strike of the night. Powell, patient for his first 20 deliveries, then joined the range-hitting revelry with ruthless precision.

West Indies plundered 19 sixes and 16 fours. Only three overs — the first two and the 11th — passed without a boundary. If the first 10 overs yielded 115 runs, the last 10 produced a whopping 139.



With scoreboard pressure sky-high, Zimbabwe unravelled. Left-arm spin twins Akeal Hosein and Gudakesh Motie methodically dismantled the chase. For Zimbabwe, it was a harsh initiation into the Super Eight, while for the West Indies, it was a statement steeped in swagger.

The scores: West Indies 254/6 in 20 overs (Shimron Hetmyer 85, Rovman Powell 59, Sherfane Rutherford 31 n.o., Richard Ngarava 2/47, Blessing Muzarabani 2/42) bt Zimbabwe 147 in 17.4 overs (Brad Evans 43, Akeal Hosein 3/28, Matthew Forde 2/27, Gudakesh Motie 4/28).

Toss: Zimbabwe.
PoM: Hetmyer.

India should turn smarter after Proteas reality check

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
AHMEDABAD

If the opening match against the United States of America was seen as a muffled wake-up call, the encounter involving South Africa was a rude jolt. India’s winning streak in the ICC Twenty20 World Cup was finally snapped as the Proteas flourished at the Narendra Modi Stadium here on Sunday.

The Men in Blue had their rivals hobbling at 20 for three but the middle overs choke never happened. David Miller and Dewald Brevis stitched a kinetic 97-run partnership. And Varun Chakaravathy’s mystery element was snuffed out as the left-right combine of Miller and Brevis remained busy.

Lack of discipline

A lack of discipline was evident, too, as India conceded 11 extras. Even if in the death, the splendid Jasprit Bumrah pegged back the visitors, South Africa’s 187 for seven was a competitive score. The fans, tipping over 80,000, were in good cheer before it all went downhill for the defending champion.

Through this championship, India has tended to lose its opening wicket with hardly anything on the scoreboard. The highest first-wicket partnership so far has been the 25 between Ishan Kishan and Sanju Samson against Namibia. Otherwise, it has always been a case of a single digit and an instant breach.

Abhishek Sharma’s sudden dip in form, evident in



Need of the hour: The Men in Blue have to pull up their socks and put in a much better display from here on. VIJAY SONEJI

three zeros and a brief 15, has meant that the middle-order is often forced to salvage the innings. In a fickle arena that the T20Is are, Abhishek should be able to turn it around, but still, in a global tournament, there is not much elbow room.

Suryakumar Yadav has resigned himself to be the binding glue instead of being the force-multiplier that the captain usually is. It is a direct reflection of the muddled top-order in which Tilak Varma is yet to fully get into his groove.

This young Indian outfit is obviously part of the selector’s long-term plan. Still, men like K.L. Rahul,

Shubman Gill, Yashasvi Jaiswal and Rishabh Pant have been kept out.

Add to that the retirements of Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma, and it is imperative for Suryakumar’s men to get past these massive vacant shoes.

Looking ahead, the think-tank has to figure out if it is prudent to bench vice-captain Axar Patel. The games against Zimbabwe and the West Indies are ‘must-win’ ones, especially after India’s Net Run Rate plunged to -3.8. This still remains a good team, but some operational rust has to be quickly sandpapered away.

Buoyant England takes on Pakistan

Abhishek Saini
PALLEKELE

England will be keen on extending its winning momentum and securing a semifinal berth when it faces Pakistan in their T20 World Cup Super Eight match at the Pallekele International Cricket Stadium here on Tuesday.

Having breezed past Sri Lanka in its opener, a second win in Group 2 will assure Harry Brook’s side of a place in the top four. But a straightforward route will emerge for England only after it clears Pakistan’s spin hurdle.

The English batters were made to sweat by Sri Lanka’s Dunith Wellalage and Maheesh Theekshana, who combined for five for 47 in eight overs on Sunday.

Pakistan’s spinners — greater in number and variety — can put England under an even sterner examination. Skipper Salman Agha is likely to deploy the tweekers for at least three-fourths of the innings, including the death phase (16-20), where Usman Tariq has nabbed seven batters at an economy of just 6.27.



Nippy customer: Archer will pose a stiff challenge to Pakistan. AFP

England’s batting problems are exacerbated by the lean run of Jos Buttler, who has single-digit scores in his last three outings.

But some batting reinforcement might come its way on Tuesday, given the fresh pitch in use and dry conditions before the contest.

For all the spin at its disposal, Pakistan would not mind a slightly easier surface if it can spark its dormant batting order to life.

SUPER EIGHT

Today’s match



Pallekele, 7 p.m.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 31

England 23 | Pakistan 9 | NR 1

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1, 2 & JIHOOTSTAR

After a washout against New Zealand in Colombo, Pakistan needs a win to keep its fate in its own hands, which means there is little room for errors. Sahibzada Farhan has been the silver lining for Pakistan’s batting this tournament but would be on his toes against Jofra Archer’s nip and pace.

England’s spinners, led by Will Jacks’ three for 22, tore through Sri Lanka’s top-order in the last match. And if offered conducive conditions, would be waiting to show they are no less than their Pakistan counterparts.

Farhan wants Pakistan’s batting unit to shoulder collective responsibility

Abhishek Saini
PALLEKELE

Pakistan opener Sahibzada Farhan on Monday backed the side’s misfiring batting unit to step up against England in their T20 World Cup Super Eight match here.

Area of concern

“We have collapsed in our batting. We are doing well with our bowling, the spinners particularly. But we will have to think about batting because if you look at T20 cricket, your top three or four should be able to score more runs. We have not been able to do that.

Unpredictability

“Sometimes the top-order gives you a good partnership, sometimes it’s the middle-order. T20 is such that it doesn’t depend on one person. I think this is a team game and everyone should take responsibility,” Farhan said.



Having a ball: Farhan has been the highest run-scorer so far in this tournament. AFP

With 220 runs from four innings, Farhan is the highest run-scorer this tournament. Against England, Farhan is likely to be tested by Jofra Archer up front. But the 29-year-old is ready for the challenge.

“It is no big deal to face Archer. We have faced him earlier too. We also have good wickets back home and bowlers who can bowl at 145 (kmph). He must have planned how to bowl against me. But I have also planned. Hopefully, we will have a good contest,” Farhan said.

Farhan has been the highest run-scorer so far in this tournament. AFP

Giant-killer J & K up against a classy Karnataka in maiden final

The two have been the most well-rounded sides this season; the summit clash is set to feature this edition's highest run-getter Smaran, and the second and third-best wicket-takers Nabi and Shreyas; pitch has a green look on match eve

RANJI TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
HUBBALLI

Kashmir to Kanyakumari is a slogan that is often invoked to epitomise the geographical grandeur, vision and diversity of India. In sport, few tournaments symbolise this quite like the Ranji Trophy, the nation's prestigious domestic cricket competition.

As many as 38 teams take part, and matches are held in every nook and corner – in foothills of the Himalayas, the fertile Deccan Plateau, against the backdrop of the tea gardens of the North East and near the Great Rann of Kutch.

From Tuesday, this premier tournament will get a final befitting its stature when Karnataka takes on Jammu & Kashmir at the KSCA Rajnagar Stadium here.

Karnataka is not quite Kanyakumari but they are close enough, and there hasn't been a Ranji final between two regions in Independent India that are as topographically distant.

In terms of cricketing excellence this season, they are joined at the hip.

Karnataka and J & K are the most well-rounded sides and the summit clash is set to feature this edition's highest run-scorer R. Smaran (950), and the second and third-best wicket-takers in Aqib Nabi (55) and Shreyas Gopal (46).

Karnataka is pedigreed, having won the coveted trophy eight times. It has a star-studded team with Test players like K.L. Ra-



Face-off: Opener Rahul and pace spearhead Nabi could prove crucial to the fortunes of their respective sides. K. MURALI KUMAR

hul, Mayank Agarwal, Devdutt Padikkal, Karun Nair and Prasidh Krishna. As many as four – Rahul, Karun, Shreyas and Mayank – were part of the southern powerhouse's last Ranji-winning squad in 2014-15.

J & K is an upstart turned top dog, looking for its maiden red-ball crown in its first-ever final. It has momentum, having felled fancied outfits like Madhya Pradesh and Bengal away from home in the knockouts.

And there is both hun-

ger and belief, qualities best exemplified in the success of pacer Nabi (99 wickets in two seasons) and the transcendence of captain Paras Dogra (only the second batter after Wasim Jaffer to score more than 10,000 runs in the Ranji Trophy).

Fitness worries However, for these two line-ups to bring their A-games, it is not just about form but also fitness. While skipper Padikkal expressed happiness with his

recovery from the finger injury, J & K had a scare on Monday when all-rounder Vanshaj Sharma limped out of training and opener Shubham Khajuria was stretched off with a back strain.

Conditions will be testing as well, for day-time temperatures are set to hover in the mid-30s.

The pitch wore a green look on match eve and was being watered. If it holds up for five days, Karnataka's first home final since Mysuru 2010 could be a

cracking affair.

The teams (from): Karnataka: Devdutt Padikkal (Capt.), K.L. Rahul, Mayank Agarwal, Karun Nair, R. Smaran, Kruthik Krishna, Shreyas Gopal, Vidyadhar Patil, Prasidh Krishna, V. Vyshak, Shikhar Shetty, Mohsin Khan, K.V. Aneesh, K.L. Shrijith & Vidwath Kaverappa.

Jammu & Kashmir: Paras Dogra (Capt.), Shubham Khajuria, Yawer Hassan, Shubham Pundir, Abdul Samad, Kanhaiya Wadhawan, Abid Mushtaq, Aqib Nabi, Yudhvir Singh, Vanshaj Sharma, Sunil Kumar, Kawal Preet Singh, Sahil Lotra, Dikshant Kundal & Umar Nazir.

In-form batting line-up gives freedom to the bowlers, says Padikkal

N. Sudarshan
HUBBALLI

Karnataka may not have had as sensational a victory as Jammu & Kashmir in its Ranji Trophy semifinal, but captain Devdutt Padikkal said that overcoming Uttarakhand – by virtue of the first-innings lead – will hold his side in good stead ahead of Tuesday's final.

Run-fest

The eight-time champion totalled as many as 1,059 runs to drown Uttarakhand, with the captain himself notching up his highest First Class score of 232.

“Scoring over 1,000 runs is definitely a big confidence boost,” the 25-year-old said on Monday. “Not just the batters but for the bowlers too. Knowing that the batting line-up is able to put on a show like that gives them confidence and



Glory beckons: Dogra and Padikkal will be keen to land the big prize. K. MURALI KUMAR

the freedom to really enjoy themselves with the ball.”

Padikkal expressed hope that the Hubballi wicket will be as run-filled. In its last four visits to the crease here across three matches, Karnataka has scored in excess of 500 thrice.

Two of those contests have ended in victories

and it has taken the first-innings lead in the other.

The home team also has a 4-0 win-loss record against J & K in the Ranji Trophy. “Looks like a good pitch,” Padikkal observed.

“We have always enjoyed playing in Hubballi. It is a beautiful city to play cricket in. Hopefully, it will be good for us”.

We will be sticking to the basics like we have done before: Dogra

N. Sudarshan
HUBBALLI

The first six questions in Monday's captains' media briefing ahead of the Ranji Trophy final between Karnataka and Jammu & Kashmir were all addressed to the home skipper Devdutt Padikkal.

J & K captain Paras Dogra sat quietly but all the time displaying a quiet confidence. In a way, it was representative of his outfit's season – unfancied, unheralded but with a

proud seat at Indian cricket's high table.

“We are relaxed and there is not too much tension,” the 41-year-old declared on the eve of his side's maiden Ranji summit clash.

“It is a very big thing to play the final and we are trying to be calm and composed.

“We will be sticking to the basics like we have done before.”

One of the stand-out features of J & K's journey this edition has been the out-

right victories it has registered against five former champions in Delhi, Hyderabad, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, and Bengal.

Facing another big team, replete with stars, doesn't appear to faze its players.

“We have beaten sides in their homes [Delhi, MP and Bengal] and that gives us a big boost,” Dogra said.

“We have played star-studded teams before. We have good skill level and a good batting line-up. So, we are confident.”

Indian women hope to continue momentum, Aussies eye revenge

Press Trust of India
BRISBANE

Having secured a stunning T20I series triumph, reigning world champion Indian women will have the psychological edge when it takes on Australia in the first ODI here on Tuesday.

What makes the series even more significant is the fact that one of Australia's greatest players, Alyssa Healy, will be making her swansong ODI appearance in the three-match rubber. She will be ending her illustrious career after the one-off Test against India starting on March 6 in



In full flow: India's batting mainstay Smriti has been among the runs. X@BCCIWOMEN

Perth. For India, Kashvee Gautam, Harleen Deol and Pratika Rawal will replace Arundhati Reddy, Bharti

Fulmali, and Shreyanka Patil. Star opener and India's batting mainstay Smriti Mandhana is in fine

form after her match-winning 82 in the third T20I.

The teams (from): Australia: Alyssa Healy (Capt.), Sophie Molineux (Vice-capt.), Darcie Brown, Nicola Carey, Ashleigh Gardner, Kim Garth, Alana King, Phoebe Litchfield, Beth Mooney, Tahlia McGrath, Ellyse Perry, Annabel Sutherland, Georgia Voll, Georgia Wareham.

India: Harmanpreet Kaur (Capt.), Smriti Mandhana (Vice-capt.), Shafali Verma, Renuka Thakur, Shree Charani, Vaishnavi Sharma, Kranti Gaud, Sneha Rana, Deepti Sharma, Richa Ghosh (wk), Uma Chetry (wk), Amanjot Kaur, Jemimah Rodrigues, Kashvee Gautam, Harleen Deol, Pratika Rawal.

Match starts at 9.20 a.m. IST

AROUND THE CITY



All smiles: The Mumbai team, which won the TNCA-Tagore Sports u-14 boys' quadrangular tournament title.

Vignesh, Sachin star as TN gains lead

Left-arm spinners P. Vignesh and Sachin Rathi scalped four wickets each and helped Tamil Nadu take a crucial 69-run first-innings lead against Punjab on day three of the C.K. Nayudu Trophy (under-23) quarterfinal at New Chandigarh on Monday.

The scores: TNadu 399 & 25/2 in 10 overs vs. Punjab 330 in 137 overs (Harnoor Singh 46, Yuvi Goyal 41, Mayank Gupta 58, Eish Rao 50, Harshdeep Singh 74 n.o., P. Vignesh 4/84, Sachin Rathi 4/70).

Ashwin, Shanmathi emerge champions Ashwin Sairam and S. Shanmathi Sree won the u-19 boys' and girls' titles, respectively, in the Chennai District Chess Association selection championship at the Jawaharlal Nehru stadium. The top-four in the open, u-15, and u-19 categories, along with the top-two in the remaining categories, will represent Chennai in the State championship.

Other winners: open: S. Haridev. **Boys:** u-7: Kavin Krishna; u-11: Siddharth Anuj; u-15: Pranav Ganeshprabhu. **Girls:** u-7: Ravanika Shivaram;



Proud moment: The winners of the first Carlsen State-level children's and open chess tournament.



Triumphant lot: The winners of the Chennai District Chess Association selection championship.

u-11: R. Thigazhini; **u-15:** J. Priyanka.

Arnav comes up trumps Arnav Maheshwari finished with 5.5 points from six rounds to become the open category champion of the first Carlsen State-level children's and open chess tournament.

Other winners: Boys: u-8: S. Jeshvik (6/6); **u-11:** K. Shivin (6.5/7); **u-14:** P. Vishnuvel (7/7); **u-25:** T. Santhosh (5.5/6). **Girls:** u-8: M. Aditi Bai (5/6); **u-11:** J.B. Varnika (5.5/6); **u-14:** P. Kashika (5.5/6); **u-25:** V. Saganapriya (6/6).

Nishad's five-for helps Mumbai claim title Left-arm spinner Nishad

Parab took five for 51 as Mumbai secured a 113-run first-innings lead on day two of the final to win the TNCA-Tagore Sports u-14 boys' quadrangular invitational tournament title at the Gojan-A ground on Monday.

The scores (final): Mumbai 246 & 13 for no loss decl. in 6 overs drew with Andhra 133 in 66.2 overs (Ch. Akshith Reddy 37, Nishad Parab 5/51, Rajveer Lad 3/40). **Special award: Player-of-the-Tournament:** Shardul Fagare (Mumbai).

State-level chess tournament Mount Chess Academy will conduct the Casagrand fourth State-level children's chess for boys

and girls on March 1 (Sunday) at the Casagrand International School in Kandigai. Competitions will be held in u-8, u-10, u-12 and u-17 categories. Call R. Yamuna at 90436 90467 or H. Santhanam at 98405 83157.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: G.R. CA XL1 Super Sports u-14 inter-school tournament, Reddy's Sumangali-B (turf), 7 a.m.

Football: IA&AD (South Zone) tournament, inauguration, guest of honour, Narmadha IA&AS, Principal Director - Regional Capacity Building and Knowledge Institute, JN indoor stadium-B, 9.30 a.m.

LIVE TELECAST

Ranji Trophy (final): Star Sports Khel & JioHotstar, 9.20 a.m.

Australia Women vs India Women: 1st ODI, Star Sports 3 & JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.

Men's T20 World Cup: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 7 p.m.

ISL: Sony Sports Ten 2 & Fan-Code, 7.30 p.m.

Champions League play-offs: Sony Sports Ten 2, 5 & LIV, 11.15 p.m. & 1.30 a.m. (Wednesday)

EURO LEAGUES

Associated Press
LONDON

Eberechi Eze reignited Arsenal's title ambitions in the Premier League by being the scourge of Tottenham once again. Three months after scoring a hat trick against Spurs, the England midfielder netted two more goals in a 4-1 away win on Sunday. Viktor Gyokeres also scored twice for the leader.

The Gunners regained their five-point lead, but Manchester City has a game in hand and still has to host Mikel Arteta's team



Heroic: Eze tormented Spurs once again. REUTERS

in the league in mid-April.

In LaLiga, Barcelona took advantage of Real Madrid's stumble and regained the lead with a 3-0 win over relegation-threatened Levante.

Barcelona moved one

point ahead of Madrid, which had won eight in a row in the league before losing to Osasuna.

In Serie A, AC Milan lost more ground to city rival Inter Milan after a 0-1 loss to Parma at home in a

match which saw Milan midfielder Ruben Loftus-Cheek hospitalised after a collision with the Parma goalkeeper.

Top results: Premier League: Tottenham 1 (Kolo Muani 34) lost to Arsenal 4 (Eze 32, 61, Gyokeres 47, 90+).

LaLiga: Barcelona 3 (Bernal 4, De Jong 32, Lopez 81) bt Levante 0; Celta Vigo 2 (Aspas 85-pen, 90+5) bt Real Mallorca 0; Villarreal 2 (Comesana 31, Gueye 45+6-pen) bt Valencia 1 (Ramazani 27-pen).

Serie A: AC Milan 0 lost to Parma 1 (Troilo 80); Roma 3 (Cristante 59, Ndicka 77, Pisilli 86) bt Cremonese 0.

Bundesliga: Heidenheim 3 (Dinkci 20, Ibrahimovic 34-pen, Conteh 82) drew with Stuttgart 3 (Fuehrich 5, Mittelstaedt 44-pen, Undav 88).



Ray of hope: Vaishnavi's performances are a shot in the arm for Indian women's tennis.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Vaishnavi keen to build on her impressive run

The excellent results in the W100 ITF tournament earn her 65 ranking points; the 21-year-old is currently India's No. 2 behind Sahaja

TENNIS

Nihit Sachdeva
CHENNAI

Vaishnavi Adkar may have been on the receiving end of a 6-0, 6-1 loss to Belgium's Hanne Vandewinkel, World No. 124, in just 56 minutes in the W100 ITF Bengaluru final on Sunday but her mere presence had ended a 17-year wait for Indian women's tennis.

No Indian woman had reached the summit clash of a tournament at a W100 or higher level since Sania Mirza's runner-up finish at the Pattaya Open, a WTA 250 event, in 2009. With a series of stunning performances on the KSLTA courts, the 21-year-old Vaishnavi, who hails from

Pune, added her name to the mix as the country's search for a new female singles star.

Ranked 690 in the world, Vaishnavi needed a wildcard to enter the tournament. In the opening round, she took down fellow wildcard and 19-year-old Shruti Ahlawat. What followed was a streak of career-best wins over Japan's Mai Hontama (World No. 220), Australia's Taylah Preston (148) and Thailand's Lanlana Tamarudee (126).

Her run in the Garden City came courtesy of a steady improvement in her first-serve percentage with every round and some fearless ball-striking, especially from the backhand wing.

"Serve is something that I've been working on a lot

because I don't really have a big serve, but it has gotten better. It's helped me in getting more points. Backhand is something that comes very naturally to me since I started playing tennis. It is one of my favourite shots," said the 5'6" tall Vaishnavi, who recently joined the Rohan Bopanna Tennis Academy after training under Kedar Shah in Pune from 2014 to 2025.

World University Games bronze medallist Vaishnavi gained 65 ranking points, rising to 466 in the WTA Rankings and becoming India's No. 2 behind Sahaja Yamalapalli (397).

It also puts the reigning National Champion in contention for a spot in the Indian team for the Billie Jean King Cup Asia-Oceania tournament set to be held in April in New Delhi.

Mohun Bagan eases past Chennaiyin

ISL

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

Mohun Bagan Super Giant continued its winning run in the Indian Super League with a comfortable 2-0 victory over Chennaiyin FC at the Salt Lake Stadium on Monday. Australian striker Jamie Maclaren opened the scoring late in the first half, while compatriot Dimitri Petratos sealed the win midway through the second period.

Mohun Bagan gradually built up momentum, consistently attacking through the flanks, with Liston Colaco and Brazilian Robson Robinho delivering repeated crosses into the Chennaiyin box. Despite sustained pressure, the visitors' defence held firm and denied any clear chances to Petratos and Maclaren.

The breakthrough came when Anirudh Thapa delivered a precise through-pass that split the CFC de-

fence and found Maclaren, who calmly slotted the ball past substitute goalkeeper Samik Mitra. Chennaiyin had earlier been forced into a change after first-choice 'keeper Mohammad Nawaz was injured in a goalmouth collision around the half-hour mark.

After the restart, the home team pressed for a second goal to secure the contest. The insurance strike arrived in the 65th minute. Left-back Subhash Bose whipped in a pinpoint cross to the far post, where Petratos met it with a powerful volley. Although Mitra managed to get a hand to the ball, he could not prevent it from bulging the net.

The result marked Mohun Bagan's second consecutive win of the campaign, which took its tally to six points from two outings. Chennaiyin suffered its second successive loss.

The result: Mohun Bagan Super Giant 2 (Jamie Maclaren 45+3, Dimitri Petratos 65) bt Chennaiyin FC 0.



On the prowl: Petratos' second-half goal sealed Bagan's win.
DEBASISH BHADURI

Gill, Abhishek, Nain, Rishabh and Samrat in the fray



Sports Bureau

Taking on the leadership challenge head-on, Shubman Gill displayed the best of his batting ability during the Test series in England, and has also assumed charge of India's ODI team ahead of the next World Cup cycle. Gill's opening partner for Punjab, Abhishek Sharma, took the T20 world by storm, adding a new gear at the top of the order with his belligerent batting.

Forward Abhishek Nain shone brightest as Indian hockey had a subdued 2025, banging in goals in the FIH Pro League and the Asia Cup. Joining him in the shortlist is compound archer Rishabh Yadav, who enjoyed a breakthrough year, winning medals in the World Archery Championships. Samrat Rana became the first Indian pistol shooter to win a senior World Championships title in an Olympic discipline.

All these performers have been nominated for the coveted Sportstar of the Year (Male) honour in the eighth edition of the Sportstar Aces Awards. Vote for your favourite star by scanning the QR code until February 28.

Additionally, there are 19 Jury Awards, which will be deliberated on by an elite panel headed by legendary Indian cricketer Sunil Gavaskar.

Olympic gold medallist Abhinav Bindra, former India hockey captain M. M. Somaya, chess great Viswanathan Anand, and Olympians Anjali Bhagwat and Aparna Popat complete the jury.

There will also be a separate Chairperson's Award for Sports for Social Good, which will honour individuals or organisations that have used the power of sports to make our world a better place.



Bindra's tenure as IOC athletes' commission vice-chair ends

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Indian shooting legend Abhinav Bindra on Monday announced the end of his eight-year tenure as the vice-chair of the International Olympic Committee's (IOC) athletes' commission.

The 43-year-old Bindra, who became India's first individual Olympic gold medallist at the 2008 Beijing Games, has been replaced by Kenyan rugby player Humphrey Kayange in the panel that was re-jigged at the Winter Olympics in Italy.

"Serving athletes from across the world has been one of the most meaning-



Bindra. FILE PHOTO

ful chapters of my journey in sport. To be entrusted with their voices, their concerns, their hopes and their dreams is a responsibility I have never taken lightly," Bindra wrote on social media.

"Every conversation, ev-

ery decision, every moment at the table was guided by one simple belief that athletes must always remain at the centre of the Olympic Movement."

Describing his colleagues as extraordinary, Bindra said that each one of them tried to strengthen athlete representation and ensured their voices were heard and respected.

"I leave this role with deep pride in what we have built and with optimism for what lies ahead. The future of athlete representation is strong because it is driven by courageous, thoughtful and passionate individuals who believe in something larger than themselves," Bindra said.

WESTERN RAILWAY CONSTRUCTION WORKS
Deputy Chief Engineer (Construction)-I, Western Railway, Indore (MP) invites Tender No: **INDUJN/SIMHA/STHA/02**.
Name of Work: Earthwork & Blanketing in embankment/cutting in formation of BG line including yards, bridge approaches etc., Construction of bridge work (Major/ Minor/Road Under Bridges, sub structure and super structure) as per Railway's approved Design and Drawing, construction of Retaining/Toe wall/Diversion Drain, Construction of passenger amenities, Foot Over Bridge, yard drain, Supply & spreading of machine crushed stone ballast, Laying and linking of BG track for Main line, loop lines and Points & Crossing etc. in section/yards, Transportation of P.Way materials, Welding of Rails, and other incidental miscellaneous works etc. between Nalkheri station (Excluding) – Chittaman Ganesh in connection with new Ujjain Bypass line for Simhastha-2028. **Approx. Cost:** ₹ 87,93,03,376.92. **EMD:** ₹ 45,46,500/-.
Date & Time of Submission of Tender: Upto 15:00 Hrs., 17.03.2026. **Date of Opening of Tender:** On 17.03.2026 at 15:30 Hrs. Complete details of tender including eligibility criteria are available on E-Tender portal www.ireps.gov.in and at the Notice Board in the office of Deputy Chief Engineer (Construction)-I, Western Railway, Indore, opposite Platform No.1, Indore. 1141
Like us on: facebook.com/WesternRly

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MINISTRY OF MICRO, SMALL & MEDIUM ENTERPRISES, GOVT. OF INDIA
2 DAYS GOVERNMENT CERTIFICATION ON YOUTUBE BUSINESS TRAINING
How to Start YouTube Business
Course Duration: 2 Days **(ONLINE)** **Date:** 28 Feb & 01 March 2026 **Time:** 5:30 PM to 8:30 PM
Course Content: Professional YouTube channel Setup, YouTube videos, Reels & Shorts, Video Shop, Equipments Handling, Video Editing, Voice Dubbing, Title Animation, Content Creation, Audience Targeting, YouTube monetization, Subscribers Increasing tips, YouTube business Type, Analytics, Page Branding, Earning Money, Attracting Viewers, Investment Cost, Video creation platform, How to create a video, Thumbnail designing, Youtube script Writing, How to Promote your Business/Yourself in youtube using AI & Chatgpt more topics
Fees: Rs.3,000/- (Study material in soft copy shall be provided)
Coordinator: 9818676612, 9818528498, 9686564246
Government of India certificate will be awarded

THE HINDU
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DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE
Commissionerate of Agriculture,
Seshadri Road, Bengaluru – 560001
No.: DDA(F&M)/MNR/INM/Re-RFP/2026-27 Date: 23.02.2026
e-REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RfP) NOTIFICATION
Technical and Financial Proposals are invited through GoK e-procurement portal from the registered Manufacturers/ Authorized distributors for Carrier based Bio-fertilizers, Liquid based Bio-fertilizers, VAM-Biofertilizer, Green Manure seeds (Diancha, Sunhemp & Phillipasara (*Phaseolus trilobus*)), Zinc sulphate (21% & 33%), Borax (10.5% & 14.5%), Ferrous sulphate (19%), Magnesium sulphate (9.5%), Micronutrient Mixtures, Gypsum, Agricultural Lime, Dolomite, Vermicompost, Organic Manure, Phosphate Rich Organic Manure, Potash Derived From Rhodophytes, Non-edible de-oiled Neem Cake and City Compost (Bulk & Packed Supply) required for various Departmental programmes for the year 2026-27. These Agricultural inputs are required for supply to farmers under different schemes of the Department.
REQUEST for PROPOSAL(RfP) document is available in the e-Procurement website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>. Suppliers must be accompanied by a Common Earnest Money Deposit (CEMD) for an amount of Rs.50,000/- which should be paid online through e-Procurement portal using any of the following payment modes: Credit Card-Visa or Master card, Debit card-Visa or Master card, Internet banking, and offline payments through Remittance at the Bank counter using challan, National Electronic Fund Transfer (NEFT/RTGS). The Applicant has to further submit a Performance Bank Guarantee as per the Technical Proposals submitted along with the Copy of the documents uploaded, one day before or on the day of opening of technical proposal to "Deputy Director of Agriculture (Fertilizer and Manure), Commissionerate of Agriculture, Sheshadri Road, Bengaluru".
Suppliers should upload the documents through e-Procurement website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> on or before 24.03.2026 within 05:00 P.M. The hard copies of the documents which are not uploaded online through e-procurement portal will not be accepted. The Proposal Scrutinizing Committee will open the Technical Proposal on 26.03.2026 at 11:00 A.M. at Samrudhhi Conference Hall, Department of Agriculture, Sheshadri Road, Bengaluru – 560 001. The date of Financial Proposal opening will be communicated later. Estimated value of the RfP is approximately Rs. 9.02 Crore.
DIPR/CP/ILC/5832/2025-26 **Sd/-, Director of Agriculture**

TAMILNADU INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED (TIDCO)
19-A, Rukmini Lakshmiipathi Road, Egmore, Chennai – 600 008
CIN:U65993TN1965SGC005327
e-TENDER NOTICE
Notice No. TIDCO/HR/Manpower/2025-26/1 Date: 24.02.2026
Tamil Nadu Industrial Development Corporation Ltd (TIDCO), a Government of Tamil Nadu Enterprise requires manpower for its Registered Office at 19-A, Rukmini Lakshmiipathi Road, Egmore, Chennai – 600 008 and its various projects in the State. In this context, TIDCO invites Manpower Agencies to submit proposals for undertaking the services described in the Tender document.
Interested firms can download the tender from the website <https://tidco.com> and <https://tntenders.gov.in> at free of cost.
The Schedule for bidding process is as follows:-
1. The last date for submission of Proposals/Bids is at or before 15:00 Hours IST on 25.03.2026, through <https://tntenders.gov.in>,
2. The Technical Proposals/ Bids will be opened at 16:00 Hours IST on 25.03.2026.
The Managing Director
Tamilnadu Industrial Development Corporation Limited
19-A, Rukmini Lakshmiipathi Road,
Egmore, Chennai – 600 008.
E-mail: cmd@tidco.com , Website: <https://tidco.com>
DIPR/1320/TENDER/2026

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER
Tender Notice No. SnT_e Tender ADA_25_26_20. On behalf of President of India, Senior Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer, S. E. Railway, Adra, Pin-723121, West Bengal invites following e-tender for the following works: **Name of the work:** Installation and commissioning of new EI at Chandrakona Road in connection with eliminating the facility of DN main cum UP loop by provision of UP loop line and Passenger Platform of Adra Division. **Tender Value:** ₹ 8,98,30,907.62. **Closing date & time of tender** is 10.03.2026, 11:00 hrs. Details are available at website: www.ireps.gov.in (PR-1223)

TAMIL NADU WATER SUPPLY AND DRAINAGE BOARD
INVITATION OF BIDS – TWO COVER – ITEMWAR TENDER SYSTEM (E-Submission)
IFB No. 40/ F.W.S to Olaikuda/DO I/CW/2026/Dt.19.02.2026
Funding Pattern Deposit Work
Eligibility Registered Class I Contractors (Civil)
Tender Invitee The Chief Engineer, TWAD Board, Madurai – 625 007
Download Period 26.02.2026 to 12.03.2026 upto 15:00 hours
EMD Payable Online Mode or eBG through E-Tendering website "<https://tntenders.gov.in>"
Pre Bid meeting 05.03.2026 at 11:00 hours at the office of the Tender Invitee
Bid Submission 12.03.2026 before 15:00 hours at the office of the Tender Invitee. Digitally signed encrypted Tenders through E-Tendering website "<https://tntenders.gov.in>"
Bid opening 13.03.2026 at 15:30 hours at the office of Tender Invitee E-Tendering website "<https://tntenders.gov.in>"

Name of work	Appx. value (including 18% GST)	Bid Security
Providing 100 KLD of Water Supply to Indian Navy 4N Detachment at Olaikuda, Rameswaram in Ramanathapuram District from Ramnad CVSS under deposit work (Construction Period: 6 months and Trial run 3 months and Paid maintenance 12 months)	Rs.2.04 crore	Rs. 1.53 lakh

DIPR/ 1326 /TENDER/2026
SAVE WATER, CONSERVE WATER, EVERY DROP COUNTS **Chief Engineer (I/c), TWAD Board, Madurai.**

THE HINDU PRESENTS SCHOOL BUZZ
A Newspaper exclusively curated for School Students
SDG EXPO HOSTED
Pon Vidyashram Senior Secondary School, Valasaravakkam hosted their SDG Expo 2030, "Sustainova 2030", transforming the campus into a vibrant space of innovation and sustainable thinking. Students from all grades presented research-based projects and models aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals, covering clean energy, water conservation, waste management, and inclusive growth. Parents appreciated the confidence and clarity of the young presenters. The Management commended the students and staff for their purposeful efforts. The expo concluded on an inspiring note, reinforcing the school's commitment to nurturing responsible, future-ready citizens.

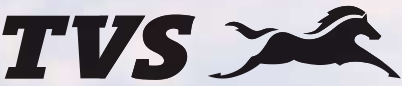
DECENNIAL CELEBRATIONS HELD
Union Christian Public School (CBSE), Chetpet marked their Decennial Year at the Union Christian Association Auditorium, celebrating ten years of academic and holistic growth. The event was graced by Mr. Ajit Issac, members of the Union Christian Association, Principals and Vice Principals of neighbouring schools, former Correspondents, Principals, Clergy, and Sisters. Former Correspondents, the Principal, and Mentors were felicitated for their leadership. Cultural performances and a special video highlighting the school's journey added vibrancy. The institution expressed gratitude to their founders and looked ahead with confidence.

PROUD ACHIEVEMENT
Zion International Public School celebrated the success of Rekha V., a Class VIII student, who excelled at the Invitational Boxing Tournament conducted by the Blue World Boxing Association at Bolarum. The event featured Cub, Under-Junior, Sub-Junior, Junior, and Youth categories, with 155 participants from several states. Representing Tamil Nadu, Rekha V. won the gold medal in the 46–49 kg category and received the Overall Champion Trophy. The Dean, the Principal, and Dr. N. Vijayan, Chairman of the Zion and Alvin Group of Schools, congratulated her on this remarkable achievement.
For Subscription related queries, please contact Subramaniam P: Handphone: +91 98408 98088 | Email: subramaniam.p@thehindu.co.in

Government of India
MINISTRY OF ROAD TRANSPORT AND HIGHWAYS
(DEPARTMENT OF ROAD TRANSPORT AND HIGHWAYS)
NEW DELHI
NOTIFICATION
R.C.No.LA/NH-45/A1/533/2025 DATED: 20.02.2026
Notification under sub section 3D and 3G(3) of the National Highways Act 1956
Whereas the Central Government declared that the lands situated in Pappanappattu Village in Vikravandi Taluk of Villupuram District specified in the schedule annexed, for the public purpose i.e., building (Bypass / widening / four-laning, etc.) maintenance management and operation of the National Highways No. 45 (Tindivanam to Ulundurpet Section) Km. 121.000 to Km. 214.300 in Villupuram District in State of Tamil Nadu should be acquired, in exercise of the powers conferred by sub section (1) of section 3D of the National Highways Act, 1956 (48 of 1956) and published in the Government of India, Gazette extraordinary No. 790 Part. II Section 3 sub section (ii) S.O.828 (E) dated. 16.02.2026 from Page numbers 1 to 3 and in pursuance of sub-section (2) of section 3D of the said Act, the Central Government hereby declared that the lands specified in the said schedule annexed hereto, shall vest absolutely in the Central Government free from all encumbrances.
All the persons interested (owner of the land and other interested person(s)) in the lands specified in the schedule appear in person or by agent or by legal practitioner, before the Competent Authority and Special District Revenue Officer (Land Acquisition), National Highways, Villupuram at the following venue on the date and time specified below and submit claims and state the nature of the respective interests in such lands with relevant records.
SCHEDULE

DISTRICT : VILLUPURAM				TALUK: VIKRAVANDI
Sl.No	Village	Date	Time	Venue
1	143. Pappanappattu	05.03.2026	From 11.00 AM to 5.00 PM	Competent Authority and Special District Revenue Officer, Land Acquisition, National Highways Office, Collectorate Office, Villupuram.

File Number : Spl.Dro.Vpm.LA/NH-45/A1/533/2025.
District: Viluppuram <https://egazette.gov.in> Publication Date: 16th February, 2026
COMPETENT AUTHORITY AND SPECIAL DISTRICT REVENUE OFFICER [L.A] NATIONAL HIGHWAYS, VILUPPURAM



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The Axar conundrum – to be or not to be

He is a no-fuss individual with a ready smile, willing and able to perform any task he is asked to undertake; expectations were that he would take his appointed place for the Super Eight fixture against South Africa but the jinx of the vice-captaincy seemed to take him down as well

R. Kaushik
AHMEDABAD

There was a phase in the 1980s when the vice-captaincy of the Australian Test side was the least coveted position. Technically, the vice-captain is a bit of a ceremonial appointment until the designated leader is ruled out due to injury. In so many ways, the deputy is the conduit between the captain and the boys, the via medium that is a seasoned player but is still approachable for the young guns who might harbour inhibitions about going straight to the skipper for one reason or the other.

Andrew Hilditch, Ray Bright and David Hookes were all vice-captains who lost their places in the Test squad not too long into their roles. Things came to such a pass that the vice-captaincy was looked at askance; players were happy not to be considered for that position, though clearly, things have come a long way since then.

It would seem as if the vice-captaincy of the Indian Twenty20 International side currently mirrors what used to be in Australia some four decades ago. Towards the middle of last year, India's selectors pulled Shubman Gill out of 20-over hibernation and appointed him Suryakumar Yadav's deputy. The then 25-year-old hadn't featured in a T20I for more than 13 months but taken in by his glorious run in England last summer when he amassed 754 runs in his first Test series as captain and perhaps looking at him as a future all-format skipper, they brought him back into the mix for the T20 Asia Cup in the UAE, ostensibly waiting for the ongoing World Cup to end before naming him Suryakumar's replacement in the hot seat.

That experiment went horribly wrong. Gill couldn't slot back into the T20 squad with any degree of comfort or consistency. The rejig that his return to the top of the order necessitated eventually cost Sanju Samson his place in the XI, while Gill himself floundered and stuttered. Fifteen innings between September and December yielded two 40s and a third knock in the 30s, but his inconsistencies and the inability to adhere to the team plans that revolved around making the most of the PowerPlay compelled the decision-makers to, belatedly, beat a hasty retreat and dump him from their World Cup plans.

Double-edged sword
The double-edged vice-captaincy sword was then passed on to Axar Patel, who had performed that role previously too. Axar has been around for a long time, is well-liked and, beneath that gentle exterior, possesses an astute cricket brain and a steely resolve that has helped him tide over many a crisis. His captaincy chops have been honed at Delhi Capitals, whom he has led with aplomb if not the greatest success, while his uncomplicated approach to batting and bowling, allied with his deceptive and underrated fielding, make him a dream pick in any T20 team.

Axar is a no-fuss individual with a ready smile, willing and able to perform any task he is asked to undertake. Rohit Sharma and Rahul Dravid used him as a

Against South Africa, there was a pressing need to bring Axar back into the mix, given the magnitude of the occasion and his immense experience

floater at the corresponding tournament in 2024, and Axar's value with the bat manifested itself gloriously in the final when he was pushed up to No. 5 to partner Virat Kohli after India lost Rohit, Rishabh Pant and Suryakumar with not many on the board.

Kohli took his time, maybe a little too much time, to hit his straps after a promising start devolved into a middle-overs struggle, while Axar got on the bike and sped away to ensure that there was no tangible loss of momentum. Using his smarts and his mastery of spin, he picked off four sixes, including a magnificent straight hit off Kagiso Rabada, on his way to 47 off 31 deliveries. His innings was cut short in full flow by a run-out, but he had provided the cushion when Kohli was anchoring the innings, upon which Shivam Dube and Kohli himself, finally, built to take India to what eventually turned out to be a title-winning total.

Axar's left-handed batting pyrotechnics were complemented by his left-arm spin, seemingly innocuous and unthreatening but always a potent weapon simply because he seldom leaves the stumps. Axar has no pretensions to being a prodigious turner of the ball; he does just enough to catch the outside edge or beat the inside half, and what he doesn't have by way of turn is more than compensated for with his accuracy, his variations of pace and his clever, subtle changes of release points. Sometimes, he goes round-arm to get skid, at other times, he tosses the ball up that much more to procure a modicum of turn.

At the last World Cup, he was an absolute bank with the ball. Coming into the final, he had eight wickets in seven matches and an economy of 6.89 from 18 overs. In the title round, he bowled three tidy overs for 25 until Heinrich Klaasen got stuck into him in his last over, the 15th of the South African run chase which went for 24 and brought the equation down to 30 off 30 deliveries. The rest of the cricketing world might have forgotten what Axar had done till then, but his teammates clearly hadn't. The moment he completed that over and took his cap back from the umpire, everyone from Pant to Bumrah made a beeline to offer words of encouragement and to assure him that all was well. It was heartwarming to see so many seek out the ultimate team man in a high-pressure situation, reiterating just how highly Axar is regarded by his colleagues.

When he was appointed Gill's successor, no one had any misgivings. If it came to the crunch and Suryakumar was forced to miss a game or two due to injury, everyone knew what to expect from Axar the captain. He brought wickets aplenty to the World Cup, having held his own in his limited opportunities on batter-friendly tracks at home against South Africa and New Zealand, and fell into his metronomic rhythm when he took two wickets apiece in India's first

three games while conceding just 73 runs in 11 overs.

Washington Sundar replacing him in Ahmedabad for India's final Group A league tie against the Netherlands last Wednesday hardly raised an eyebrow. For one thing, it was a 'dead' rubber inasmuch as there is any such thing in 20-over cricket. India had already secured qualification to the next stage, the Dutch were out of the competition, and the outcome wouldn't alter anything tangible. Washington was just coming off a long injury layoff and needed some game-time, so it was understandable for the think-tank to want him to shed residual rust and be prepared for future battles, if the need arose.

The Tamil Nadu all-rounder had a passable outing on his comeback, but he didn't do anything to set the Sabarmati afire. Expectations were that Axar would take his appointed place for the first Super Eight fixture against South Africa but the jinx of the vice-captaincy seemed to take him down as well, with Washington the preferred choice on the basis of 'match-ups' when the easier, more obvious option stared everyone in the face.

Hard to dispute
The logic behind Washington's inclusion is hard to dispute. South Africa have three left-handers in their top five - Quinton de Kock, Ryan Rickelton and David Miller - and India's plans revolved around getting Washington to bowl potentially two overs of off-spin in the PowerPlay against these left-handers. The leadership group, however, seemed not to have factored in Bumrah's genius. In his two-over first spell, he packed off de Kock and Rickelton, which meant Suryakumar was compelled to hold Washington back until the field spread out.

However, by the time he was brought on, Miller and Dewald Brevis were in the middle of a wonderful fourth-wicket alliance; Washington was reduced to just two overs which went for 17, and his lack of match practice was evident when he scratched around for 11 deliveries at No. 5 whilst making 11. Even before Washington's night mirrored that of India's and quickly became one to forget, the wisdom of going with the less experienced and more undercooked off-spinner at the expense of the seasoned pro that Axar is was being discussed threadbare. India's 76-run drubbing and a relatively anonymous night at the office for Washington merely exacerbated the dubious nature of the selection call, forcing the management group to resort to troubleshooting measures that seemed inadequate under the circumstances.

Whether a decision becomes a masterstroke or is pilloried for being ill thought out and counter-productive depends on whether it comes off or falls flat on its face. In this instance, however, there was a pressing need for India to bring Axar back into the mix, given the magnitude of the occasion and his immense experience and presence. If India did feel the need to have a right-arm finger spinner, then Washington could have kept his place in the XI ahead of Rinku Singh, who seems a little wasted at No. 7.

On the two occasions when he had

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THE GIST

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time and the opportunity to make a difference - against US in Mumbai in the opener when Suryakumar was at the other end, and on Sunday against the Proteas with Shivam Dube for company - Rinku has failed to come good. Maybe in Chennai, Washington's home ground, India will field both the local lad and Axar to give themselves more bowling options against Sikandar Raza's Zimbabwe on Thursday without losing too much by way of batting depth. It might appear a little extreme, but India have pushed themselves to the brink after their no-show in Ahmedabad and must now start fixing problem areas if they are not to rain on their own parade.

The hammering at the hands of South Africa has left India with no option but to win their two remaining games, by big margins if possible but not necessarily a must because they are so far back on the net run-rate count, and then hope for South Africa to come to their rescue by finishing with an all-win record. The first step towards that will be to get their collective heads out of the sand and start to accept that course-correction is inevitable. Axar getting back into the XI ought to be primary in that endeavour.

AFP & PTI

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

The number of rape cases reported in Odisha last year

2,994 Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi informed the Assembly that 2,994 rape and 7,382 molestation cases were reported in the State in 2025. The CM said 1,183 cases of sexual harassment and 115 attempt to rape cases were also reported. PTI

Number of Maoists who surrendered in Chhattisgarh in 2 years

2,704 Chhattisgarh Governor Ramen Deka declared that the State is on the verge of eliminating left-wing extremism, citing a massive crackdown with 532 Maoists neutralised, more than 2,700 surrendering and 2,004 arrested in the last two years. PTI

Flights disrupted due to drones during the Lunar New Year

50 Unauthorised drones disrupted more than 50 flights at Vietnam's Danang international airport during the Lunar New Year holiday. Two separate incidents last week saw flights delayed or forced into holding patterns when authorities detected drones flying close to aircraft. AFP

Amount utilised for flood management post-2014 in J&K

487 in ₹ crore. The Jammu and Kashmir government has expended over ₹487 crore on a series of flood management initiatives under various phases of the flood management programme, in the aftermath of the 2014 deluge that ravaged the Valley. PTI

Amount required by Ukraine to rebuild from Russia's invasion

588 In \$ billion. Ukraine needs \$588 billion to rebuild from the destruction caused by Russia's four-year invasion, a figure almost three times the country's annual economic output, the World Bank and other institutions said. AFP
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On the independence of the EC

An independent Election Commission is the bedrock of Indian democracy. To ensure that it remains so, various safeguards are built into the basic structure of the Constitution

LETTER & SPIRIT

C.B.P. Srivastava

Free and fair elections are key to a successful and vibrant democracy, a maxim included in the Basic Structure of the Constitution via *Indira Gandhi versus Raj Narain* (1975). However, in recent times, the fairness of the electoral process in India has been under question for many reasons, culminating in a resolution by the Opposition alliance to remove the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC). These controversies centre around the issue of alleged 'vote theft', and the manipulation of electoral rolls in the much-talked about Special Intensive Revision (SIR).

It has been alleged that the Election Commission (EC) has allowed massive irregularities in voter lists, specifically targeting minority and Opposition-supporting voters. It was alleged that the SIR in Bihar was rushed and designed to delete voters in order to target minorities. The names of approximately 65 lakh voters have been deleted during the SIR exercise which was challenged in the Supreme Court.

This is quite a casual way of doing away with a citizen's 'right to vote'. Adult franchise as provided in Article 326 of the Constitution is the bedrock of democracy. Any procedural impropriety would affect its merit and sanctity.

On selecting the EC

The process of appointing election commissioners had caused controversy when the Government passed the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Office and Terms of Office) Act, 2023, which regulates the appointment and removal of the CEC and election commissioners, replacing the 1991 Act. The 2023 Act stipulates that election commissioners should be appointed by the President based on a selection committee comprised of the Prime Minister, a Union Minister and the Leader of Opposition. It was alleged that the passing of the Act was in contravention of the decision of the Supreme Court in *Anoop Baramwal versus Union of India*, 2023 in which the Court held that the Chief Justice of India should also be included in the committee. However, this provision was removed which created a controversy on the grounds that the independence of the EC would be adversely affected. The Act has been challenged again in *Jaya Thakur versus Union of India*, 2024. The next hearing for the same is scheduled for March 2026.

The Constitutional mandate

The Constitution of India, under Article 324, provides for a permanent Election Commission with powers of superintendence, direction and control of the elections of the President, Vice-President, Parliament and of the legislature of the States. This constitutional basis and permanency of the Commission creates a background for its independence. The 2023 Act provides that the CEC will hold office for six years or until the age of 65, whichever is earlier. By far the most significant provision ensuring independence of the EC is the provision for the removal of the CEC and other election commissioners. Clause (5) of Article 324 says that the CEC can be removed only in the manner prescribed for the removal of a Supreme Court judge under Article 124(4), which are either



Speaking out: Activists from various groups stage a protest against the SIR at Freedom park in Bengaluru on February 7. ALLEN EGENUSE. J

proved misbehaviour or incapacity. Under Article 324(5), the CEC's conditions of service cannot be varied to their disadvantage during their tenure.

The removal of other election commissioners is done by the President on the advice of the CEC. However, the Supreme Court in *Vineet Narain versus Union of India*, 1997 held that the CEC shall not give his advice *suo motu*. This provision strikes a balance between the executive power and the independence of the election commissioners.

The CEC's position

Article 324 provides for an EC with a CEC and other commissioners, and also includes a provision for regional commissioners. In 1989, the commission was made multi-member but the two additional posts were abolished in 1990. Again on October 1, 1993 after drawing strength from clause (2) of Article 324, it was made a multi-member commission permanently which was validated by the Supreme Court in *T. N. Seshan versus Union of India* (1995).

Interestingly, Clause (3) of Article 324 provides that when any Election Commissioner is so appointed the CEC, he/she shall act as the Chairman of the EC. The language of Article 324 makes it crystal clear that the CEC is appointed and commissioned as the commissioner having certain exclusive powers, and in case of making the Commission multi-member, he shall preside over the meeting as its chairman. The idea behind this provision is to ensure that the conduct of elections is done by an administrator and at the same time to make the decision of the Commission consensus-based or democratic. Such provisions also ensure the independence of this constitutional body.

The procedure to remove the CEC is

very complex and rigorous. It is a quasi-judicial Parliamentary procedure. The complexity of the process ensures its independence from any possible arbitrary action by the government. While the Representation of the People Act of 1950 and 1951 focuses on electoral procedures, voter registration, and candidate qualifications, Section 11 of the CEC and other ECs (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Terms of Office) Act, 2023 gives the procedure to remove the CEC and other Commissioners.

For the removal of the CEC, Article 324 (5) shall be read with Article 124(4) in order to understand the grounds for removal and the procedure.

Section 3 of the Judges (Inquiry) Act, 1968, deals with the investigation into misbehaviour or incapacity by a commission member. It says that if notice is given to the Lok Sabha, at least 100 members must sign, while in the case of the Rajya Sabha, the minimum number of signatories to such a motion shall not be less than 50. Following this, the Speaker or, as the case may be, the Chairman may admit or refuse the motion.

The Speaker or Chairman thereafter constitutes a three-member committee comprising the Chief Justice of India or a Supreme Court Judge, the Chief Justice of a High Court and a distinguished jurist.

In order to ensure coordination between the two Houses of Parliament, a provision is made that if the notice is given to both Houses on the same day, the committee shall be constituted only after both Houses accept the motion.

Further, definite charges must be framed and communicated on which investigation needs to be conducted. The CEC should be given reasonable time and opportunity to present his statement of defence. This is a provision which ensures the protection of the Doctrine of

Natural Justice by way of protecting the 'Rule of Fair Hearing'. This is again one of the most significant features of India's Constitution. In the case of allegations of any physical or mental incapacity, medical examination by a medical board appointed by the Speaker or Chairman, as the case may be, needs to be conducted.

The political angle

Though the Opposition has said that it will adopt democratic tools to move the motion against the CEC, it is unlikely to get passed as the ruling alliance holds sufficient majority in Parliament. The ruling government has rejected the allegations of any bias. The moot point is that constitutional bodies must be well-respected by all, be it citizens, ruling parties or the Opposition; otherwise, it sends a wrong signal to the masses across the country.

All political parties need to consider that constitutional or statutory bodies operate according to the provisions provided in the Constitution or in the respective statutes. While dissent against the actions of such bodies is not wrong, it should also be considered that the politicisation of the Constitution or constitutional bodies would be detrimental to Indian democracy.

The political safeguard provided by the Constitution must be taken care of and any dilution would be politically sensitive mainly because it would affect fairness in the electoral process and in the balance of power between the Government and independent and credible democratic institutions. The rule of thumb in Indian democracy is that it thrives on a blend of liberality and command, by balancing the authority of the state with the liberty of its citizens.

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THE GIST

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